

CM Yogi inspects Noida Airport ahead of March 28 inauguration

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Noida

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Sunday inspected the Noida International Airport to review preparations for its inauguration by Prime Minister Narendra Modi on March 28, officials said.

The chief minister also carried out an on-site inspection of arrangements for the inauguration ceremony and later held a review meeting with public representatives and senior officials, issuing necessary directives.

The inauguration of the airport and its cargo terminal, along with the foundation stone laying for a maintenance, repair and operations (MRO) facility, is scheduled to be performed by the prime minister on March 28.

According to an official statement, during the inspection, Adityanath reviewed the route designated for the prime minister's visit and examined key locations, including the passenger terminal, cargo terminal, rally



Uttar Pradesh CM Yogi Adityanath during the on-site inspection of the Noida International Airport

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venue, parking areas, access routes and helipad.

He also issued instructions to ensure seamless arrangements at all sites.

The chief minister subsequently chaired a review meeting at the airport auditorium, where detailed discussions were held on preparations for the inauguration, event management, security arrangements and opera-

tional plans, it stated.

Emphasising the expected presence of public representatives, dignitaries, media personnel and a large number of people, Adityanath directed officials to ensure meticulous planning and effective execution of all arrangements.

To give the event a grand and world-class stature, he called for extensive branding and publicity campaigns to

maximise outreach, according to the statement.

The chief minister also directed that all essential facilities—including accessibility, sanitation, uninterrupted power supply, drinking water, restrooms, security, traffic management, transportation, fire safety, medical services and signage—be completed ahead of schedule, it added.

Over 60 held in four-day anti-crime drive in Rohini

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

More than 60 people were arrested in a four-day anti-crime drive in northwest Delhi's Rohini area, as police carried out a large-scale operation targeting organised and street crime, officials said on Sunday.

The operation was conducted between March 18 and March 21. It involved 44 police teams that carried out coordinated raids across 79 locations. Police also checked 165 known offenders during the intensified enforcement exercise.

The drive focused on multiple categories of crime, including illegal arms, illicit liquor, gambling, and theft. Police said the action was part of a broader effort to curb criminal activities and increase surveillance in the district.

In the crackdown on illegal arms, police registered 10 cases under the Arms Act and arrested 11 people. During the operation, officers recovered one revolver, a .32 bore pistol, five country-made pistols, 12 live cartridges, four knives, and a scooter.

Action against illicit liquor



led to 14 cases under the Excise Act. A total of 14 people were arrested in these cases. Police seized 48 bottles and 13,993 quarters of illegal liquor. They also recovered one car, a tempo and a scooter used in transportation. In cases related to gambling, police registered 11 FIRs and apprehended 34 individuals. An amount of Rs 30,380 was recovered as stake money during these operations.

Separate actions were also taken against street crime. Police arrested two alleged snatchers and recovered a stolen mobile phone and a scooter. In another case, an auto-lifter was apprehended with six high-end motorcycles, officials said.

Police said that four of the arrested individuals are history-sheeters. Several others have prior involvement in criminal activities, indicating repeat offences in the area. In addition to arrests, preventive action was taken against 768 individuals under various legal provisions. Police also booked 20 people for drinking in public places during the drive.

Officials said the operation aimed to create a deterrent effect and improve the sense of security among residents. Increased patrolling and targeted raids were conducted based on intelligence inputs and crime patterns.

The coordinated effort across multiple teams

POLICE SAID THE ACTION WAS PART OF A BROADER EFFORT TO CURB CRIMINAL ACTIVITIES AND INCREASE SURVEILLANCE IN THE DISTRICT

allowed police to cover a wide area within a short period. Raids were conducted simultaneously at identified hotspots and locations linked to known offenders. Police said such drives will continue in the coming days to maintain pressure on criminal networks and prevent unlawful activities.

The Rohini district has witnessed periodic enforcement drives in recent months, focusing on both organised crime and street-level offences. Officials said sustained action is necessary to keep crime under check.

Police added that monitoring of repeat offenders and surveillance of sensitive areas will be further strengthened as part of ongoing efforts. The Delhi police have said that further investigation is underway in all registered cases.

Atishi slams Assembly functioning

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Leader of Opposition (LoP) in the Delhi Assembly, Atishi, has written to Speaker Vijendra Gupta raising serious concerns over the functioning of the Delhi Legislative Assembly, stating that the treatment meted out to the Opposition since the formation of the eighth Assembly is not in line with democratic values or established legislative procedures.

Referring to the conduct of proceedings across sessions, she has urged the Speaker to ensure that the House is run in a fair, lawful, and democratic manner.

Earlier, addressing a press conference, Atishi demanded the immediate revocation of the suspension, warning that if the decision is not rolled back, the Opposition will completely boycott the Budget session and no AAP MLA will participate in the proceedings. She asserted that if the voice of the people is not allowed inside the House, it will be raised on the streets. However, she said,



the legislature, Parliament or Assembly, does not belong only to the ruling side. Along with the ruling party, the Opposition also has an important role in the Assembly. Parliament and Assemblies exist so that elected representatives of the people can sit there and raise the voice of the public. They can question government policies and highlight before both the public and the government the work that is not being carried out properly.

In the letter to the speaker, Atishi stated, "After the formation of the Eighth Assembly, both the ruling party and the Opposition unanimously elected you as Speaker with the expectation that, given your experience, the House would function in a democratic and lawful manner. It is well known that in a democratic system, the Legislative Assembly is not merely a platform for the government but a powerful institution run through

the participation of both the ruling party and the Opposition, where the House functions through healthy discussion, dialogue, and deliberation. The responsibility of the Opposition is to raise issues in the House and hold the government accountable if it ignores public interest or fails to act in accordance with its promises."

The Delhi Assembly LoP said, "However, it is with deep regret that I must state that from the first sitting of the first session to the first sitting of the fourth session, your approach towards the Opposition has been not only concerning but also inconsistent with democratic values. Expelling the entire Opposition, including the Leader of Opposition, from the House for raising issues of public interest and criticising the Government, and not only from the House but also from the Assembly premises, is against the dignity of the House."

IP University launches M.Tech in Robotics, AI from 2026

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Guru Gobind Singh Indraprastha University (IP University) has introduced a new M.Tech programme in Robotics and Artificial Intelligence from the 2026-27 academic session.

The course aims to tap into the growing demand for advanced technology skills in India.

The programme will be offered by the University School of Information, Communication and Technology (USICT), one of the university's key technical institutes. Officials said the course is designed to equip students with skills aligned



to emerging industry needs.

A senior faculty member, Prof. Pushpender Bharti, said the demand for professionals in artificial intelligence and robotics is rising rapidly across sectors. "The scope for Robotics and Artificial Intelligence in India is expanding due to govern-

ment initiatives, a strong startup ecosystem, and increasing adoption in sectors like healthcare, finance, manufacturing, and agriculture," he said. He added that the programme aims to prepare students for roles such as AI engineers, data scientists, and robotics

engineers, which are in high demand in both established companies and startups.

The university has announced 21 seats for the programme. Admissions will primarily be based on merit through valid GATE scores in relevant disciplines. "If seats remain vacant after admitting GATE-qualified candidates, they will be filled through the university's Common Entrance Test (CET)," an official said. Remaining seats, if any, will be allotted based on CUET merit.

The last date to apply for the programme is March 31, 2026, in line with other courses offered by the university. To be eligible, candidates must have at least 60

per cent marks or equivalent in specified qualifications. These include B.Tech or B.E. degrees in disciplines such as computer science, information technology, electronics, electrical, mechanical, and aerospace engineering. Candidates with postgraduate degrees such as M.Sc. in fields including computer science, electronics, physics, mathematics, statistics, and related areas are also eligible. Officials said the interdisciplinary eligibility criteria reflect the broad application of robotics and AI across different domains.

The university said the course will focus on both theoretical knowledge and practical application.

Govt moving forward to uproot terrorism, Naxalism: CM Saini

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gurugram

Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Sunday said that over the past decade, under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the Government has been continuously moving forward to uproot terrorism and Naxalism from the country.

The chief minister was addressing a Shaheed Diwas programme organised in Gurugram by the Home Developers Association in honour of Central Reserve Police Force personnel mar-

tyred in Dantewada, Chhattisgarh, an official statement said.

About 75 CRPF and state police personnel were killed in a Maoist attack on April 6, 2010, in the thick Mukrana forests of Chhattisgarh's Dantewada district.

Paying tribute to the soldiers killed in Dantewada, Saini said that a true patriot sacrifices everything for the nation and assured that the State Government stands firmly with the families of martyrs.

The BJP leader said that the mantra of "Nation First" is guiding the country today.



Under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, India has strengthened not only its border security but also its internal

security over the past 11 years.

On this occasion, Saini paid a floral tribute to Shaheed Bhagat Singh,

Rajguru and Sukhdev and announced the installation of a statue of Shaheed Bhagat Singh at Leisure Valley Park.

He also presented a cheque of Rs 38.25 lakh to DIG CRPF Param Shivam for the welfare of the personnel of the reserve police.

The central and state governments are running several schemes in this regard, he said. He said that this programme is dedicated to those 'Veeranganay' who have lost the biggest support of their lives but are still moving forward with courage.

PUBLIC NOTICE
I, Ashok Batra S/o Late Sant Ram Batra and Praveen Batra W/o Ashok Batra, R/o C-57A, Shiv Vihar, Uttam Nagar, New Delhi, hereby disown our son Manish Batra from all our movable and immovable properties. We have severed all relations with him. Any person dealing with him shall do so at their own risk. We shall not be responsible for his acts.
Deponents
Ashok Batra
Praveen Batra

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given on behalf of Shri Ankit Sharma who is Purchasing of PLOT NO. 6, BLOCK A, MEASURING 100 SQ. MTR., SITUATED IN VILLAGE RANGPURI, DELHI from (1) Smt. Kamla (2) Mrs. Sushma Daughter (3) Mrs. Sarita Ahlawat (4) Mrs. Manita (5) Mrs. Lalita Rani who owned the said Property vide Court Decree and Order issued by the Court of Senior Civil Judge at Patiala House Courts, New Delhi, on March 12, 2024 Suit No. CS SCJ 650/21, now Shri Ankit Sharma, Smt. Shyama Sharma and Shri Parth Sharma intend to purchase and mortgage the subject property for the financial assistance from Aditya Birla Housing Finance Limited That, Original Conveyance Deed dated 11/01/2021 executed by POI in favour of Shri Mahender Singh, Shri Shiv Charan, Smt. Kamla Devi and Shri Ram Murti duly registered in the office of SR-VII-Delhi, as registration No. 109, Addl. Book No. , Page Nos. 38-40, Volume No. 7757, Dated 11/01/2021, has been lost/misplaced/not available. FIR already lodged vide LR No: 170780/2026 dated 17/03/2026 To comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any Person having any type of claim/right/title/interest/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within 15 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc. Lucem Legal LLP N-161, Ground Floor, Saira Tower, Gautam Nagar Near Yusuf Sarai Community Centre New Delhi-110049 Contact # 011-40046316 & 41687327

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given on behalf of Shri Digambar Singh to inform to the public at large that Shri Digambar Singh is purchasing the PLOT NO.19, AREA MEASURING 6350. YDS. OUT OF KHASRA NO. 18/19, SITUATED IN THE AREA OF VILL. MATIALA, DELHI STATE DELHI COLONY KNOWN AS T-BLOCK, UTTAM NAGAR, NEW DELHI, from of Shri Manish Aggarwal who became owner through General Power of Attorney, Agreement to Sell & Will dated 02.01.2001 which was executed by Smt. Phoolwati Devi and same to be financed & mortgaged by Aditya Birla Housing Finance Ltd., So, to comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any Person having any type of claim/right/title/interest/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within 15 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc. Lucem Legal LLP N-161, Ground Floor, Saira Tower, Gautam Nagar Near Yusuf Sarai Community Centre New Delhi-110049 Contact # 011-40046316 & 41687327

PUBLIC NOTICE
It is to inform to the public at large that Sh. Ramesh Pal Singh (R.P. Singh) is the owner of Plot Bearing P.C. No. 29, Area Measuring 316 Sq. Yds., Approx., part of Khassra No. 402/2 & 403/2, Situated at Village Satbari, Gausahala Road, Tehsil Saket, New Delhi vide Sale Deed dated 11.09.2025 (Doc. No.2025/7/1146) executed by M/s. Balaji Metropolis Private Limited and same will be financed & mortgaged by Aditya Birla Housing Finance Ltd., That, M/S Balaji Metropolis Private Limited became owner of the subject property vide Notarized GPA dated 30.08.2025, Notarized SPA dated 30.08.2025, Agreement to Sell dated 30.08.2025 & WILL dated 30.08.2025 executed by Smt. Sarita. So, to comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any Person having any type of claim/right/title/interest/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within 7 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc. Lucem Legal LLP B-938, Second Floor, Opp. SBI Bank Sector 2 Noida UP-201301 Contact# 0120-4269379

Constable injured after being hit by car in Janakpuri, driver held

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Delhi Traffic Police constable was injured allegedly after being hit by a car whose driver attempted to flee during a drunken driving check in the Janakpuri area, an official said on Sunday.

The police have seized the vehicle and apprehended the accused driver, Nilesh Kumar, a resident of Dwarka's Bagdola area in Delhi, police said. The incident took place on Saturday evening near Bharti College



on Lal Sai Marg when traffic personnel were conducting routine checks to curb drunken driving, he said. The traffic team, comprising Sub-Inspector Gurdeep Singh and Constable Mohan Pal, signalled a car to stop on suspicion. However, the

driver allegedly tried to escape and, in the process, rammed the vehicle into the constable, police said.

"The constable was hit head-on and fell onto the bonnet of the car before being thrown onto the road after a few metres," a senior police officer said.

The police have seized the offending vehicle and issued a challan under relevant sections of the Motor Vehicles Act, including drunken driving, dangerous driving, jumping a red light and misbehaviour, the officer said.

Three arrested for robbing transport company employee

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Three men were arrested for allegedly robbing a transport company employee of ₹23 lakh at gunpoint near Shastri Nagar Metro station in north Delhi, police said on Sunday. They said the robbery was executed at an insider tip-off.

On February 23, Kuldeep Sharma, 28, collected the cash from Keshav Puram and was returning to his office in Kishanganj on a motorcycle.

Around 7.40 pm, two men



on a motorcycle intercepted him near the metro station, pointed a gun at him, and fled with the cash bag, the police said.

CCTV footage showed that the two robbers had been following Sharma all along, with a third separating

midway. He was later identified as Kalaram, a Rajasthan native, who remains at large, the police said

The police arrested one of the riders, 31-year-old Monu, from Bhalswa Dairy on March 9, with a pistol, a live cartridge, and Rs 3.95 lakh in cash on him.

"Monu and the absconding accused had planned the robbery after receiving information about the movement of cash. He also arranged the weapon and the motorcycle used in the crime," an officer said.

Traders pitch reforms to CM: CAIT seeks level playing field, simpler rules

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Confederation of All India Traders (CAIT) has submitted a set of recommendations to Chief Minister Rekha Gupta for the upcoming Delhi Budget.

The traders' organisation called for regulatory reforms, a digital push, and protection for small traders amid rising competition from e-commerce platforms.

Under the theme "Viksit Vyapar - Samridh Dilli", the

traders' body has proposed measures aimed at improving ease of doing business while preserving Delhi's position as a major trade hub. CAIT Secretary General and MP Praveen Khandelwal said the recommendations focus on simplifying processes and strengthening the traditional retail sector. "These steps are essential to support traders and ensure balanced growth in Delhi's trade ecosystem," he said.

Among the key proposals is the introduction of a single-



window clearance system to reduce delays in approvals. The body has also called for the decriminalisation of minor compliance violations and time-bound permissions to ease regulatory pressure on businesses.

CAIT has further recommended complete digitisation of inspections to improve transparency and reduce physical interface with officials.

It has also proposed the creation of district-level facilitation centres to assist

traders with documentation and approvals.

A major concern flagged by the traders' body is competition from e-commerce and quick commerce platforms. CAIT has sought a strong regulatory framework to curb predatory pricing and what it described as unfair trade practices.

"The aim is to ensure a level playing field for offline traders who are facing increasing pressure," an official familiar with the proposal said.

Delhi Assembly Budget Session to commence with *kheer* ceremony

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Assembly's Budget Session will commence with a '*kheer*' ceremony on Monday, even as the Opposition AAP threatens to boycott it. On the first day of the Budget session, the Rekha Gupta Government will table Delhi's economic survey report in the House.

The first day of the session will also witness the tabling of various reports of the Controller and Auditor General (CAG) related to the audit of Delhi's finances, revenue, children in need of care, Delhi Jal Board, among others.

As per the business listed for Monday, the chief minister will lay the State Finance Audit Report of the Comptroller and Auditor General of India (CAG) relating to the Government of NCT of Delhi for the year



ended March 31, 2021 (Report No 01 of 2022); the CAG report on Revenue, Economic, Social and General Sectors and PSUs relating to the Government of NCT of Delhi for the years ended March 31, 2020 and 2021 (Report No. 03 of 2022); the CAG report on Performance Audit Report on Children in Need of Care and Protection relating to the Government of NCT of Delhi

for the year ended March 31, 2021 (Report No 01 of 2023); and the State Finance Audit Report of the CAG relating to the Government of NCT of Delhi for the year ending March 31, 2022 (Report No 02 of 2023).

The Chief Minister also tabled the CAG report on the functioning of the Delhi Jal Board for the year ended March 2022 and the "func-

tioning of universities of GNCTD for the year ended March 31, 2023".

BJP MLA Shikha Roy will move the "censure motion for the resolution brought by the Opposition in Lok Sabha for the removal of the Lok Sabha Speaker" under Rule 114. The Budget session is a crucial period in the legislative calendar, during which key financial and policy matters will be discussed and decided upon.

The chief minister, who also holds the finance portfolio, will table her second annual budget on March 24.

The Delhi Government's annual Budget for 2026-27 will focus on industrial growth, investment and job creation. Interacting with industrialists, Gupta said that her Government is preparing an industry-friendly Budget and sought their suggestions on it.

Govt plans mega medical merger to boost PG seats

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government plans to merge three major public hospitals to create an integrated medical institution, modelled after AIIMS. The move aimed to sharply increase Postgraduate (PG) seats and strengthen medical education and research in the capital.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta stated that the integration of Guru Teg Bahadur Hospital (GTB), the Delhi State Cancer Institute (DSCI), and the Rajiv Gandhi Super Speciality Hospital (RGSSH) will address the fragmentation of resources and enhance both healthcare delivery and academic output. A senior official said, "The integration will allow pooling of faculty and infrastructure, which directly translates into more PG seats and better training opportunities." The plan proposes to combine departments that currently func-



tion separately across the three institutions. Officials said this will optimise the use of faculty, many of whom are currently under-utilised due to distribution across different hospitals.

Under existing norms, an associate professor can support two PG seats, while a professor can support three. By merging faculty strength, the number of PG seats is expected to rise significantly without immediate large-scale hiring.

The impact is likely to be most visible in key depart-

ments. Radiology seats, which are currently limited or absent in some institutions, could increase to around 22. Pathology seats may rise to nearly 26, while anaesthesia could see a jump to about 48 seats.

Officials said the increase will also come from filling vacant faculty positions, many of which remain unoccupied across the three hospitals. The integration is also expected to introduce new PG courses in specialised fields where seats do not currently exist. At DSCI, around

26 new PG seats could be added in areas such as radiation oncology, nuclear medicine, cancer research, and intensive care.

Similarly, RGSSH is expected to add about 14 PG seats in super-specialty disciplines, including cardiology and cardiac surgery.

The Government is also working on a parallel plan to expand undergraduate medical education. The Chief Minister said the increase in faculty strength, bed capacity, and patient load will create conditions necessary to expand MBBS seats in the future. To support this, the government plans to invest in academic infrastructure, including hostels, laboratories, and lecture theatres.

In a separate but related move, the government aims to upgrade the Institute of Human Behaviour and Allied Sciences (IHBAS) into a facility on the lines of the National Institute of Mental Health and Neurosciences (NIMHANS).

Police bust LPG hoarding racket

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police busted an illegal LPG hoarding and black-marketing racket in southwest Delhi's Mahipalpur area on Saturday. The police have also arrested three men and recovered 74 cylinders along with equipment used for illegal gas transfer.

The accused, Krishna (33), Dinesh Sahu (46), and Mithilesh (39), were allegedly running the operation for the past three years, supplying LPG cylinders without authorisation to local residents.

Deputy Commissioner of Police (South-West) Amit Goel said the operation was carried out following specific intelligence inputs. "Acting on credible information, our team



conducted a raid and unearthed illegal storage and black marketing of LPG cylinders. Such activities pose serious safety risks and will be dealt with strictly," he said.

The raid was conducted on Saturday at a premise in Mahipalpur identified as K-845. A team from the Anti-Auto Theft Squad (AATS) reached the spot after receiving a tip-off about illegal LPG

activities. During the search, police recovered 70 domestic LPG cylinders and four commercial cylinders. Out of these, 57 cylinders were filled, while the rest were either partially used or empty.

Officials also seized a Tata Ace Gold vehicle used for transporting cylinders, along with weighing machines and metal pipes used for transferring gas.

BJP marks PM Modi's 8,931 days in office

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi BJP president Virendra Sachdeva on Sunday said Prime Minister Narendra Modi has completed 8,931 days in public office, calling it a "historic record" and crediting him with steering both Gujarat and the country on a path of development.

Addressing a press interaction, Sachdeva said the Prime Minister's tenure, which began on February 24, 2002, reflects a long period of governance marked by continuity and political acceptance.

"During his 8,931-day journey of public service, he has guided first Gujarat



and then the entire nation onto a unique path of development," Sachdeva said.

He added that Modi's political career spans multiple electoral mandates. According to Sachdeva, Modi was elected four times as a Member of the Legislative Assembly in Gujarat and three times as a Member of Parliament in the Lok Sabha.

LG Sandhu performs *Joda Seva* at Gurudwara Bangla Sahib

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Sunday offered prayers and performed "*Joda Seva*" at Gurudwara Bangla Sahib on the occasion of the Jyoti Jot Diwas of Guru Angad Dev Ji.

Sources said Sandhu chose to clean the shoes of devotees (*Joda Seva*), a form of service seen as an act of humility in Sikh tradition. He was also offered the opportunity to perform "Langar Seva", which involves serving food and cleaning utensils, but opted for *Joda Seva* instead.

People familiar with his routine said this was not the



first time Sandhu undertook such service. They said he has been performing Jod Seva for years, including during his student days. According to those aware of his background, Sandhu would regularly visit Gurudwara Sis Ganj Sahib while studying at St

Stephen's College and perform similar service. He is also said to have continued the practice after joining the Indian Foreign Service.

Sources added that during his early postings in Delhi, he would visit Gurudwara Rakab Ganj Sahib and engage in *Joda Seva*.



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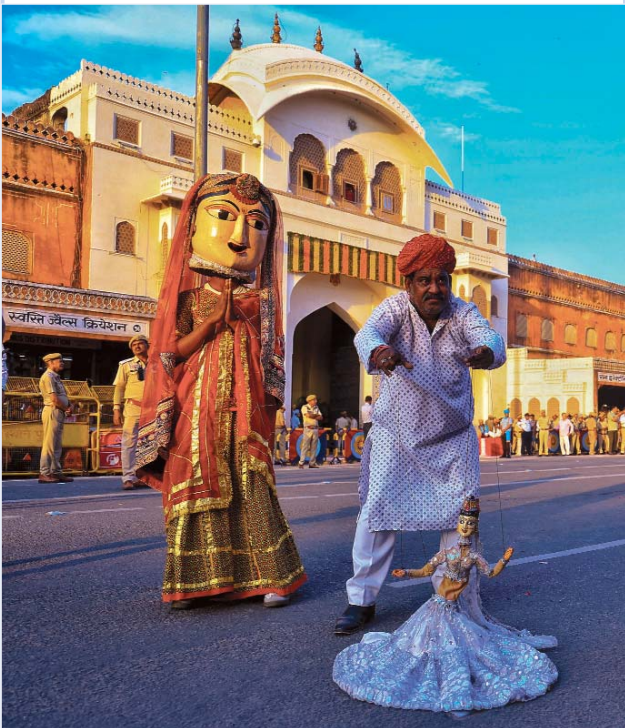
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Rajasthani folk artists performing during the Gangaur festival procession at Choti Chaupar in Jaipur

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PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Lucknow

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Sunday said there is a heavy demand for Indian nursing professionals across the world.

Addressing a function to distribute job letters to 1,228 nursing professionals, 131 of them men, at the Lok Bhavan here, Adityanath said, “Recently, I went to Japan, where there is a heavy demand for Indian nursing professionals. The same is the case in Germany and Korea. If you go to European countries, there is a feeling among people that Indian nursing professionals will do good work.”

The chief minister also said that before 2017, Uttar Pradesh was in a poor condition. “From 1947 to 2017, there were only 17 government medical colleges in



Uttar Pradesh. If we include the private sector, the total was 40. “Today, the number of government-run medical colleges has surpassed that of the private sector.

The total count has risen to 81 in just nine years,” Adityanath said.

The chief minister also claimed that the mindset under which a parallel Government run by the mafia operated in the state has now been dispelled.

“Previously, every district had its own mafia network, and the Government departments were no different. ‘Mafias’ dictated them. From there, we have moved towards a policy of ‘one district, one medical college’, establishing one such institute in every district,” he said.

The chief minister also said that to encourage more women to take up nursing in different parts of the country, modules should be created that impart knowledge in regional languages, such as Marathi, Telugu, Malayalam, Tamil, or Bangla.

“Institutions like the King George Medical University, the Sanjay Gandhi Postgraduate Institute of Medical Sciences, and the Ram Manohar Lohia Institute of Medical Sciences have established simulation labs within their premises.

Through these facilities, they are working to ensure that students become proficient not merely in theoretical knowledge, but in practical skills as well,” Adityanath said.

The chief minister said jobs to so many women on the auspicious occasion of Navratri was a positive sign of women empowerment that shows “increasing participation of daughters in society”

“Eastern Uttar Pradesh was once known for its poor healthcare system. Conditions were so bad that thousands of people lost their lives, with little attention given to their plight. Diseases like encephalitis and dengue claimed many lives every year,” he was quoted as saying in a UP government statement.

The region had become a hub of health crises, the

chief minister said. Adityanath said major reforms were undertaken to strengthen healthcare infrastructure to address these challenges. “ANM (auxiliary nurse midwife) and GNM (general nursing and midwifery) training institutes that had been closed for years were reopened. About 35 such ANM centers have been revived, and construction of 31 new nursing colleges is underway.”

He said nursing and paramedical institutions are as important as medical colleges. “If doctors lead the healthcare system, nursing staff serve as its backbone. With this vision, equal priority is being given to nursing and paramedical education. As a result, maternal and infant mortality rates have significantly declined,” Adityanath said. The chief minister said that Uttar

Pradesh has made notable progress in digitising healthcare services.

He also spoke on the scale of coverage of the Ayushman Bharat health insurance scheme, the digital health IDs created for beneficiaries, improved access to healthcare in rural and remote areas as well as telemedicine and tele-consultation services in community health centres.

Almost all state medical colleges have been affiliated to the Atal Bihari Vajpayee Medical University to streamline medical education in UP, he said.

Adityanath said the number of medical colleges in the state has increased and in the past nine years, the State Government has provided more than 9 lakh government jobs — one of the highest numbers by any state in India.

Top LeT commander Bilal Salafi killed in Muridke headquarters

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH

■ New Delhi

In a major incident reported on the day of Eid, Bilal Arif Salafi (also spelt Sarafi), a senior commander of the Pakistan-based and United Nations Security Council (UNSC) proscribed terrorist group Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT), was shot and stabbed to death inside the group's main headquarters at Markaz Taiba, in Muridke, Punjab province.

The attack took place moments after Eid al-Fitr prayers ended, when the complex was crowded with Lashkar members and leaders, including Maulana Abu Zar and Maulana Abdul Rehman Abid. According to reports, the



assailants struck quickly as they fired multiple shots, followed by multiple stabbings. They escaped without being caught immediately. No group has claimed responsibility. Pakistani authorities have issued no official statement so far.

Major Pakistani media outlets, such as Dawn and Geo TV, have not reported the incident prominently. Most media reports describe the killers as unknown assailants who fled the scene. Some accounts suggest the attack may have been an ‘inside job’ linked to internal rivalries or power struggles within the Lashkar members and their ISI handlers. The reported involvement of a female assailant has added to speculation about a pre-planned strike. One different version has claimed that Salafi was killed by his own family members in a domestic dispute.

There have been reports of growing discontent within the Lashkar as of January 2026. The

assessment by the Indian security agencies has noted rifts, with some commanders and operatives unhappy about being forced to fight Baloch insurgents or protect Chinese interests instead of focusing on anti-India operations, especially after losses in 2025 India-Pakistan clashes.

The daylight murder of Salafi has exposed the hidden power struggle among the Lashkar cadres. This killing comes at a time when Pakistan continues to face serious terrorism challenges; it has been ranked number 1 in the Global Terrorism Index.

If the attack was carried out by insiders, it could point to growing divisions inside Lashkar, which has long been seen as relatively

unified under the likes of its founder, Amir Hafiz Saeed.

Markaz is Lashkar-e-Taiba's fortified headquarters, spread over about 1.09 acres near Lahore. It serves as the group's central hub for training, indoctrination, and operations. The complex was destroyed by Indian forces during “Operation Sindoor” in May 2025, but it was later rebuilt. It is considered a high-security zone, which makes the breach by unknown attackers especially significant and has raised questions about internal security failures.

Lashkar-e-Taiba is a UN-designated terrorist organisation linked to major attacks inside India, including the 2008 Mumbai terror attack. It continues to operate in

Pakistan with the active help of the Pakistan Army, despite international sanctions.

Bilal Arif Salafi had been associated with Lashkar-e-Taiba since at least 2005 and held a prominent role in the group's recruitment and ideological operations at the Muridke centre.

He was reportedly responsible for identifying and radicalising young men across Pakistan, providing ideological training and promoting the outfit's Kashmir jihad agenda. He was actively involved in fundraising for weapons and sustaining terror activities to target Jammu and Kashmir.

He resided in Taiba Colony within Muridke alongside other senior Lashkar commanders.

BSP's strength benefits Dalits, OBCs, minorities, says Mayawati



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Lucknow

Bahujan Samaj Party chief Mayawati on Sunday said that whenever and wherever her party has strengthened its hold, Dalits, tribals, OBCs and minority communities have benefitted immensely.

In a statement, Mayawati said that it is necessary to take the master key of power into our own hands to properly implement the legal and constitutional rights given by Babasaheb Bhimrao Ambedkar for the benefit, welfare, upliftment of the bahujan across the country and for enabling them to live in an egalitarian society with self-respect.

The BSP founder, Kanshi Ram, dedicated his entire life to this cause. His unfinished mission is now being pursued with enthusiasm by Mayawati, the statement said. “The need of the hour is to work diligently to achieve the missionary objectives of security, respect and identity for the *bahujan*, and achieve electoral success,” said Mayawati.

Wangchuk receives rousing welcome in Leh

MOHIT KANDHARI

■ Jammu

Climate activist Sonam Wangchuk was accorded a grand welcome on his first visit to Leh on Sunday, after the Centre revoked his detention under the National Security Act and released him from the Jodhpur jail after 170 days on March 14.

Accompanied by his wife, Gitanjali Angmo, Wangchuk, dressed in his traditional attire, was warmly received by supporters of the Leh Apex Body (LAB) who garlanded him en route to the venue of the public rally.

Addressing the gathering, Wangchuk said he felt positive about returning to the moun-



tains after nearly six months. “I am feeling very good. After 170 days, coming to these mountains and meeting people, I hope that a new sun will rise for the cause for which we are working. We are moving forward with hope and I would like to thank the people of the entire country who supported us in this struggle.”

EC tightens vigil in West Bengal ahead of polls

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ Kolkata

Senior police officials began visiting police stations across West Bengal from Sunday as the Election Commission stepped up monitoring Assembly poll preparedness and security arrangements in the state, officers said.

During these visits, officers-in-charge at police stations were briefed on measures imperative for ensuring free and fair polling, with a strong focus on maintaining law and order and preventing any form of electoral malpractice.

In line with directives from the poll panel, police commissioners and superintendents of police have started conducting ground-



level reviews, an official in the West Bengal Chief Electoral Officer's office said.

“Senior officers have been instructed to guide local police units to ensure a peaceful, free and fair election,” he said. “The focus is on building confidence among voters and strict enforcement of measures to

curb any attempt at malpractice, including booth capturing or intimidation,” the official added.

As part of this exercise, Kolkata Police Commissioner Ajay Nand visited Bhangar police station and held meetings with officers from the division, briefing them on the

Election Commission's guidelines. “Every officer has been briefed. Electors should be able to cast their vote without fear. That is the main objective,” Nand said.

He said multiple confidence-building and preventive measures were being undertaken. “We have taken many measures, such as identifying vulnerable areas, hamlets and persons, and communicating with them,” the police officer said. He said, “To increase police presence and visibility, we are patrolling extensively. Officers are visiting different areas. There is a history of political clashes, but we have to ensure that there is no violence. If there are any signs, we will take preventive action.”

ELECTION: BLO DIES OF HEART ATTACK

Kolkata: A 54-year-old booth-level officer in West Bengal's Malda district died of a heart attack, with his family alleging that excessive work pressure related to the SIR exercise in the State caused his death.

The BLO, identified as Utpal Thakur, suffered a heart attack at around 10.30 pm on Saturday and later died, one of his family members said. He was serving as a BLO at booth number 93 in Nadapara under the Chandrapara Gram Panchayat in Chanchal-II block, Election Commission sources said. Thakur was a para-teacher at a school.

FROM PAGE - 1

Safeguard citizens amidst rising global...

PM also asked for proper coordination with State Governments to ensure no black-marketing and hoarding of important commodities.

Sources said the Cabinet Secretary gave a detailed presentation on the global situation and the mitigating measures taken so far and being planned by all concerned Ministries/Departments of the Government of India.

A detailed assessment of availability for critical needs of the common man, including food, energy and fuel security, was made. Short-term, medium-term and long-term measures to ensure the continued availability of essential needs were discussed in detail. It was also discussed that the ongoing conflict in West Asia will have significant short, medium and long-term impact on the global economy and its effect on India was assessed, and counter-measures, both immediate and long-term, were discussed.

The expected impact and measures taken to address it across sectors like agriculture, fertilisers, food security, petroleum, and power, MSMEs, exporters, shipping, trade, finance, supply chains and all affected sectors were discussed. The overall macro-economic scenario in the country and further measures to be taken were also discussed. The impact on farmers and their requirement for fertiliser for the Kharif season was assessed. The measures taken in the last few years to maintain adequate stocks of fertilisers will ensure timely availability and food security. Alternate sources of fertilisers were also discussed to ensure continued availability in the future. It was also determined that an adequate supply of coal stocks at all power plants will ensure no shortage of electricity in India. Several measures were discussed to diversify sources of imports required by chemicals, pharmaceuticals, petrochemicals and other industrial sectors. Similarly, new export destinations to promote Indian goods will be developed in the near future.

Several measures proposed by different ministries will be prepared and implemented in the coming days after consultation with all stakeholders. Union Ministers Sarbananda Sonowal (Ports and Shipping), Manohar Lal Khattar (Power), Pralhad Joshi (Food and Consumer Affairs), Kinjarapu Rammohan Naidu (Civil

Aviation) and Hardeep Singh Puri (Petroleum), NSA Ajit Doval and the prime minister's two principal secretaries, PK Mishra and Shaktikanta Das, were also present.

On March 12, PM Modi had said that the war in West Asia has triggered a worldwide energy crisis, posing a critical test of national character that requires dealing with circumstances through peace, patience and increased public awareness.

The prime minister has spoken to several global leaders since the West Asia conflict started on February 28, when the US and Israel attacked Iran. Iran has retaliated by targeting Israel and several of its Gulf neighbours.

Iran controls the Strait of Hormuz, a key shipping route through which 20 per cent of the world's energy is transported. Since the conflict, very few ships have been allowed by Iran to cross it. The blockade has resulted in severe disruptions in energy supply to many countries, including India. Since the conflict, Modi has had telephonic conversations with leaders from Saudi Arabia, UAE, Qatar, Bahrain, Kuwait, Jordan, France, Malaysia, Israel and Iran.

Large defaulters owe BOI ₹96,512 crore

Defaulting companies with dues in the range of ₹600 to ₹1,000 crore are Nagarjuna Oil Corporation (₹992 crore), ECI Engineering & Construction (₹874 crore), and Mumbai-based Rajat Pharamchem (₹789 crore), Raipur-based Vandana Vidyut (₹786 crore), Anil Ambani's Reliance Communication and Reliance Telecom (₹777 crore). Other names figured in TransUnion CIBIL's large defaulters list include Rotomac Exports (₹720 crore), Bengaluru-based Cranes Software International (₹708 crore), Patna-based Shrenuj and Company (₹674 crore), Chennai-based Thalaivar Steels (₹652 crore), Ahmedabad-based Sadbav Engineering (₹637 crore) and Mumbai-based Ashapura Garments (₹614 crore).

The large defaulters list of Bank of India also includes all bank plunders like Lanco Group (₹375 crore), promoted by former Congress MP L Rajagopal and former TDP Rayapati Sambasiva Rao's Transtroy (₹260 crore). Like other banks, Bank of India has no recoverable collateral from the companies in the large defaulter list, except

these collapsed companies' shares, which have no value now.

Pakistan's former diplomat sparks outrage...

He pointed to India's development of advanced missile systems as an example of what he described as selective scrutiny.

In his remarks, Basit went further to outline a hypothetical worst-case scenario involving US military action against Pakistan's nuclear infrastructure. He suggested that if such a situation were to arise, Pakistan would have limited strategic options, controversially stating that India could become a target in response. His comments included references to the proximity of Indian cities and past incidents, which many observers described as deeply insensitive and provocative.

Basit also spoke about shifting geopolitical alignments, noting that while ties between Pakistan and the United States may see periodic improvement, Washington's long-term strategic partnership lies with India. He compared this dynamic to Pakistan's own relationship with China, suggesting that countries pursue partnerships based on strategic interests rather than permanence. The remarks have drawn sharp criticism from analysts and commentators, who warned that such rhetoric risks escalating tensions in an already fragile regional security environment. References made during the discussion also evoked memories of past attacks, further intensifying concerns over the tone and implications of the statements.

The incident has once again highlighted the sensitivity of nuclear and security discourse in South Asia, where relations between India and Pakistan remain complex and often strained.

Iran relaxes Hormuz transit rules

Addressing the International Maritime Organisation, Iranian representative Ali Mousavi emphasised that Iran remains open to cooperation with international bodies to ensure maritime safety and protect seafarers operating in

the Gulf. Mousavi underscored that diplomacy continues to be Iran's priority, but stressed that any meaningful de-escalation would require an end to hostilities and the rebuilding of mutual trust. He also reiterated Tehran's stance that recent military actions by the United States and Israel are the primary drivers of instability in the region. The Strait of Hormuz is widely regarded as one of the most critical energy corridors in the world. Any disruption to shipping in the narrow passage has immediate and far-reaching consequences for global energy supply chains. The earlier closure had already reduced vessel movement, as shipping companies weighed the risks of operating in a conflict-prone zone.

In response, the United States has been exploring the formation of a multinational naval coalition to escort commercial vessels through the Strait. However, several members of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization have expressed reluctance to participate in direct military operations against Iran, reflecting divisions within the alliance. While Iran's latest stance suggests a willingness to ease restrictions, the situation remains highly fluid. Analysts caution that any further escalation between Tehran and its rivals could once again disrupt this vital maritime artery, with significant implications for global trade, energy security, and regional stability.

NIA investigation: Foreign nationals...

Mizoram Chief Minister Lalduhoma had flagged the issue in the State Assembly last year, noting that nearly 2,000 foreigners visited the State between June and December 2024. Many of them were not genuine tourists, and some were crossing into Myanmar for arms training. The re-imposition of the Protected Area Permit regime was partly aimed at curbing such activities.

The NIA is expected to reveal more details once the current custody period ends. Investigators are also examining whether the operation involved espionage, funding of Indian insurgent groups, or the creation of sleeper cells in the Northeast. This case highlights the growing use of India's eastern borders by foreign actors and the deepening security collaboration between India and friendly intelligence agencies.

NIA sources say the Myanmar EAGs they trained have direct ties to banned Indian outfits active in the Northeast. In a sharp breakthrough disclosed in court, VanDyke and the Ukrainians have admitted during interrogation that they conducted these trainings “on more than one occasion” and illegally imported huge consignments of drones plus jamming equipment from Europe through Indian Territory. The revelations came after a Russian intelligence tip-off triggered a three-month NIA surveillance operation.

This is not an isolated incident; it is a wake-up call. This is no random adventure. It is a geopolitical blowback. The Ukraine war has flooded the market with cheap, skilled mercenaries and drone tech. Western networks, possibly with quiet intelligence backing, are deploying them to bleed the Myanmar junta and disrupt Beijing's Belt-and-Road ambitions in Southeast Asia, sources added.

Russia, which maintains ties with the Myanmar junta, simply passed the file to its trusted BRICS partner India. Result: a three-month NIA surveillance operation and simultaneous airport swoops. For India, the stakes are existential. Mizoram's porous border has become a superhighway for foreign fighters and lethal hardware. Myanmar rebels training in Indian Territory risk reverse-flow: advanced drones and tactics reaching Northeast militants already using similar tech in Manipur clashes. Mizoram.

Ukraine has cited geopolitical motivation, demanding consular access and Ukrainian-language charges. Washington remains silent; meanwhile, Indian security agencies are hunting local facilitators in Assam and Mizoram while tracing the remaining eight members of the original 14-man team. The arrest of these foreign mercenaries has sent a crystal-clear message that India will not be anyone's unwitting playground in the new era of hybrid proxy wars. The eastern frontier is now a live theatre where Russia-China alignment, Western disruption tactics, and Northeast insurgencies collide.

Delhi's response has been swift, it's intelligence-driven and unapologetic. India has sent signals that it intends to control the script. As the investigation gains momentum, we may see more details coming out about the covert operations launched by Western intelligence agencies to keep the Northeastern NIA region of India on the boil.

GRAPEVINE

PM becomes longest-serving head of elected Govt

Press oscillates between IPS and CAPF officers

For the past few decades, IPS officers and Central Armed Police Force (CAPF) officers have been engaged in a legal battle over supremacy. CAPF officers recently secured victories in the Delhi High Court and Supreme Court, though Governments have consistently supported IPS officers. In this ongoing contest, the media finds itself torn, as reporters must present both sides due to relationships with individuals in each group. Now, in response to the court verdicts, the Government has introduced a bill aiming to reestablish IPS supremacy in CAPF. As expected, CAPF officers are preparing to challenge this new act in court. Looking ahead, Home Minister Amit Shah is slated to table the new bill in Parliament next week, reaffirming support for the IPS perspective. This means journalists covering the Home Ministry will need to maintain balanced relationships with both uniformed services.



Rahul blocks MPs ‘fortunes’ in Assembly elections

Congress has a good chance of winning in the Kerala Assembly elections. As a result, the majority of the MPs from Kerala wanted to return to their home state to become MLAs and then Ministers. This desire among Congress MPs led to a delay in announcing candidates after days of meetings. Finally, Rahul Gandhi used his veto power and ordered that no MPs from Kerala would contest in the Assembly polls.



BJP’s Bihar dilemma

The role of Bihar CM Nitish Kumar, who has just made his foray into the Rajya Sabha, has hit a roadblock in national politics. Nitish is likely to resign as CM during the first week of April. JDU hard bargained that the patriarch may be assigned a Cabinet berth/portfolio and his son Nishant as Deputy CM. Grapevine has it that Nitish may not see himself in the Union Council of Ministers due to ill health. The regional party leadership is being convinced that he may be given a responsibility as NDA office bearer, but now the BJP is in a fix since Rajya Sabha Deputy Chairman Harivansh, also a JDU man, is learnt to see a respectable entry into the NDA. The toss is now between Nitish and his trusted aide Harivansh, and the latter is understood to have won over the trust of the BJP’s leadership. The party is in a dilemma as three heavyweights, Nitish, Harivansh and the BJP chief Nitin Nabin, all hail from Bihar.



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi achieved a historic milestone on Sunday in Indian politics by becoming the longest-serving head of an elected Government in the country. With this, Prime Minister Modi has surpassed Pawan Kumar Chamling, who held office as Chief Minister of Sikkim for 8,930 days. He has now completed 8,931 days as head of Government, combining his tenure as Chief Minister of Gujarat and as Prime Minister, thereby entering his 25th year in a leadership role. The milestone is being seen as a rare and significant achievement, reflecting decades of uninterrupted public service and political leadership at the highest level. He is also the first Prime Minister of India to have been born after Independence and has secured victory in three consecutive Lok Sabha elections in 2014, 2019 and 2024, a feat that underscores political longevity and sustained public mandate. Narendra Modi first assumed office as Chief Minister of Gujarat on October 7, 2001, and continued in the role until May 21, 2014, leading the state for more than 13 years before moving to national politics. He was sworn in as the 14th Prime Minister of India on May 26, 2014, becoming the first non-Congress leader to secure a full majority in the Lok Sabha. He later

became the first non-Congress Prime Minister to complete two full terms in office and return for a third consecutive term. Top Union ministers on Sunday complimented Prime Minister Narendra Modi for setting a record of 8,931 days in public life saying this reflects his deep commitment to nation-first governance, in giving rights to the poor and enhancing the nation’s pride on global platforms. “Prime Minister Narendra Modi is now the longest-serving head of a Government in India. Pure devotion to the nation and its people defines PM Modi ji,” Defence Minister Rajnath Singh said. Union ministers, including Amit Shah, JP Nadda, Piyush Goyal, Ashwini Vaishnaw, and BJP chief Nitin Nabin hailed the prime minister, saying the “Modi era” has transformed India unrecognisably in setting new landmarks in development. Defence Minister Singh praised Modi, in a post on X, saying his life has been a continuous journey of service – from his unwavering commitment as the Gujarat CM and his dedicated leadership as the PM. “Today, he surpasses the 8,930-day record of former Sikkim chief minister Pawan Kumar Chamling, achieving a historic milestone. With 8,931 days in public office as head of Government, this moment reflects his deep commitment to nation-first governance, integrity in action, and tireless service to every



PM Narendra Modi surpassed the 8,930-day record of former Sikkim CM Pawan Kumar Chamling to become the longest-serving head of a Government in India on Sunday PTI

citizen. Heartiest congratulations to Modi Ji on this remarkable achievement,” he said. Home Minister Amit Shah said Modi’s decades of ‘seva’ (service) have shaped an era of his own. “Whether it is giving the poor their rights, setting new landmarks in development or enhancing the nation’s pride on global platforms, the Modi era has transformed India unrecognisably,” he said in a post

on X. Shah said fostering “this new India” required a lifetime’s effort and PM Modi gave it. He said serving the nation and its people without taking a holiday for more than 24 years is the manifestation of his sheer commitment. “This explains the unprecedented affection he received from people, three times as Gujarat CM and three times as India’s PM. People’s trust, affection and support for him have only grown with every passing day,” he said with a hashtag #PradhanSevakModi. The home minister also said the milestone is rooted in service, hard work and unwavering commitment. “PM Modi ji’s 8,931 days in public life, first as Gujarat CM and now as prime minister reflect a deep dedication to nation-first governance, integrity in action, and tireless service to every citizen. “A rare legacy built on unprecedented trust and unparalleled Seva,” he said. Health Minister JP Nadda said Modi’s years in Government reflect his deep commitment to the country and a constant focus on serving the people. “Under his leadership, India is moving towards the vision of Viksit Bharat, driven by people-centric policies that have empowered the poor, youth, women, and farmers,” he said.

Today, Nadda said, India stands more confident and influential on the global stage. “PM Modi ji’s work has always been about putting the nation first and bringing real change on the ground. A leadership shaped by trust, dedication, and a clear sense of purpose,” he said. BJP president Nitin Nabin said during Modi’s tenure as prime minister, the country has made rapid progress in infrastructure expansion, the digital revolution, effective public welfare schemes, and the direction of ‘Aatmanirbhar Bharat’. “The historic public mandates received in three consecutive Lok Sabha elections in 2014, 2019, and 2024 are a testament to the unwavering trust of the countrymen in him,” the BJP chief said in a message in Hindi. Railways, Information and Broadcasting Ministers Ashwini Vaishnaw posted a message in Hindi on X with a picture of the PM on Chenab railway bridge holding the tricolour: “Every moment of time... is solely and exclusively for the fellow citizen #PradhanSevakModi”. The bridge over the Chenab river in Jammu and Kashmir is the world’s highest rail bridge. Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal said with 8,931 days in public life, PM Modi’s journey of “jan seva” reflects an unwavering commitment to inclusive development.

Arunachal Pradesh to boost indigenous culture, youth power

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Itanagar

Arunachal Pradesh is building a larger movement to preserve the indigenous culture, empower youth and position the state as a strong voice in the country’s sustainable fashion ecosystem, state Textile and Handicrafts Minister Nyato Dukam said. Addressing a gathering at the closing ceremony of Arunachal Fashion Week at Naharlagen, near here, on Saturday night, he said it is not merely a fashion



show but a part of a broader initiative to preserve traditions while creating opportunities for young designers and artisans. “Today, I feel proud to serve as the Minister for Textile and Handicrafts after witnessing the talent and creativity of our designers on this platform.

Opposition MPs, activists seek rollback of transgender bill

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Opposition MPs and transgender rights activists on Sunday called for the Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Amendment Bill, 2026, to be withdrawn, saying the proposed changes could dilute their rights. The call to rollback the Bill was made at a Jan Sunwai (public discussion) held at the Press Club of India here, where participants raised concerns over its potential impact on transgender people.



Social Justice and Empowerment Minister Virendra Kumar introduced the Bill in Lok Sabha on March 13.

The Bill seeks to give a precise definition of the term “transgender” and provide graded punishments that reflect the gravity of the harm

inflicted upon such persons. It also underlines that a transgender person “shall not include, nor shall ever have been so included, persons with different sexual orientations and self-perceived sexual identities”. The proposed amendment to the existing Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Act, 2019, has triggered criticism from members of the community who say it departs from principles laid down by the Supreme Court in the landmark judgement of National Legal Services Authority vs Union of India.

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States Focus



Governor Hasnain, CM Nitish greet people on Bihar Diwas

Bihar Governor Syed Ata Hasnain and Chief Minister Nitish Kumar on Sunday extended good wishes to the people of the State on the occasion of 'Bihar Diwas'. The 114th foundation day of Bihar is being celebrated here. Bihar was carved out of Bengal Presidency in British India on March 22, 1912. The State Government has organised multiple events as part of a three-day programme (March 22 to 24) featuring folk music, traditional dances, cultural programmes and exhibitions showcasing Bihar's history and art. Hasnain "conveyed his heartfelt greetings and warm felicitations to all residents of Bihar and people of Bihari origin across the world on the auspicious occasion of Bihar Diwas," according to a statement issued by Lok Bhavan.



Rajasthan launches multilingual education initiative in schools

Rajasthan has launched a multilingual education initiative in Government schools to make learning more engaging by incorporating local dialects into classroom teaching, officials said. To bridge the gap between home and school language, the project will teach students to use commonly spoken local words, such as 'ladu', 'rotlo' and 'moto bapo' instead of the standard Hindi terms, Shweta Phagediya, Director, Rajasthan State Council of Educational Research and Training (RSCERT), said. The programme will initially be implemented in 11 districts before being expanded across the State in phases, she said.

Seat mirroring Bengal's political journey from Congress citadel to Mamata's fortress

PRADIPTA TAPADAR ■ Kolkata

In the constantly shifting landscape of West Bengal politics, few constituencies carry the historical weight and symbolism of Bhabanipur — a seat whose electoral journey mirrors the State's transformation from Congress dominance to the rise of the TMC.

Today regarded as Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee's political fortress, Bhabanipur was not always synonymous with the TMC. For decades after Independence, the seat

in south Kolkata was a Congress bastion and the home turf of some of the State's most influential political figures.

Former chief minister Siddhartha Shankar Ray contested and won from the seat both as a Congress candidate and later as an Independent. Other Congress stalwarts such as Mira Dutta Gupta and Rathin Talukdar also represented the constituency, cementing Bhabanipur's reputation as one of the party's key urban strongholds.

Leader KC Venugopal allege secret CPI(M)–BJP nexus in Kerala polls

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Thiruvananthapuram

In a sharp escalation of political rhetoric ahead of the Kerala Assembly elections, senior Congress leader KC Venugopal on Sunday launched a direct attack on Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan, alleging a covert understanding between the ruling Left and the BJP.

Addressing reporters in Thiruvananthapuram, Venugopal asserted that the United Democratic Front (UDF) is contesting the upcoming elections not to project a chief ministerial face, but to deliver what he described as a "people-driven mandate for change."

Venugopal accused the ruling Communist Party of India (Marxist) (CPI(M)) of maintaining a "secret pact" with the BJP to weaken the opposition. He claimed that this alleged nexus is reflected in candidate selections and the handling of central agency investigations.

"There is a covert understanding between the CPI(M) and the BJP. From candidate selection to stalled central probes like the Lavalin case, the signs are evident," he said, adding that even grassroots workers within the Left were uneasy about such an arrangement.

Stepping up his criticism, Venugopal accused Vijayan of "national hypocrisy," alleging double standards in his political conduct. He claimed that while the Chief Minister publicly criticizes opposition leaders, he seeks relief from



Prime Minister Narendra Modi in legal matters.

"The CM appeases Modi to delay his own central probes; he has no right to call Rahul Gandhi—who fights Adani and Modi head-on—the BJP's B-team," Venugopal said, defending the Congress leader against allegations from the Left Democratic Front.

Amid ongoing speculation over Congress's chief ministerial candidate, Venugopal clarified that the party would not project any individual for the top post before the elections.

"The Congress is not facing this election to make a specific person Chief Minister. When the UDF wins, the best person will be chosen," he said, expressing confidence that the alliance would secure over 100 of the 140 seats in the Assembly.

Venugopal also accused the Vijayan-led government of "serious failures" in governance, particularly in healthcare and law and order.

He alleged mismanagement in medical institutions and irregularities in recruitment processes, including Public Service Commission appointments.

Assam Police camp attacked by ULFA(I), 4 injured

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

At least four security personnel were injured in a militant attack on an Assam Police Commando camp in Tinsukia district early on Sunday. Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma said counter operations have been launched to nab those behind the attack. Militant group ULFA(I) claimed responsibility for the attack in Jagun area and said 'Operation Bujoni' was carried out in retaliation against Assam Police's repeated action against the banned outfit, and alleged drone attacks by the Army on its camps last year.

The attack comes ahead of the State assembly elections, scheduled on April 9. Police officer said the attack was

carried out around 2.30 am. The militants fired multiple rocket-propelled grenade (RPG) shells at the camp, with five of the launched shells exploding. Security personnel stationed at the camp immediately retaliated, leading to a brief exchange of gunfire.

Police officerz said the attack is suspected to have been carried out by a seven-member group, which escaped across the inter-State border with Arunachal Pradesh under the cover of darkness.

The four security personnel injured in the attack were taken to Assam Medical College and Hospital (AMCH) in Dibrugarh for treatment. AMCH superintendent Dhruvajyoti Bhuyan said all the injured were out of danger



An injured person receiving medical treatment at Assam Medical College and Hospital following an alleged attack at a police commando camp in Tinsukia district of Assam on Sunday

PTI

Counter operations have been launched to nab those behind the attack
—CM HIMANTA BISWA SARMA

and in a stable condition.

Confirming the attack, Chief Minister said, "An incident has happened, and it is highly condemnable. Counter operations have been launched by Assam Police and the Army, and we are confident those responsible will be nabbed." He refused to comment on the ULFA(I), claiming that the attack was carried out by it.

Meanwhile, ULFA(I), in a press statement, owed responsibility for the attack and said it was conducted

under its 'Operation Bujoni'. It maintained that the outfit had not carried out any operation against the State police as a gesture towards peace overtures of the Himanta Biswa Sarma Government, after it came into power in 2021.

However, leaders, cadres and sympathisers of the outfit were targeted by the security agencies, and many of them were killed, the ULFA(I) claimed.

It also blamed the Indian Armed Forces for conducting drone and missile attacks on its mobile camps along the India-Myanmar border in July last year. The ULFA(I) asked the State police force to "refrain from subversive activities" against the outfit, warning of retaliatory action.

Protesters clash with police outside CM Mann's residence

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Chandigarh

Police detained top Opposition leader and used water cannons to disperse protesters as they tried to force their way through barricades here on Sunday to gherao Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann's residence during a joint stir to demand the arrest of former minister Laljit Singh Bhullar, accused of abetting the suicide of a State warehousing corporation official.

Gagandeep Singh Randhawa, the district manager of Punjab State Warehousing Corporation in Amritsar, allegedly ended his life by consuming poison early Saturday, and a video appeared in which he purportedly claimed harassment by Bhullar, who resigned as minister later in the day at



Police use cannons to disperse protesters as they tried to force their way through barricades to gherao Punjab CM Bhagwant Mann's residence in Chandigarh on Sunday

PTI

the direction of Mann amid the row. The family of Randhawa told reporters in Amritsar that they will not allow a post-mortem examination and cremation until Bhullar is arrested.

The police on Saturday night booked Bhullar, his father Sukhdev Singh Bhullar, and personal assis-

tant Dilbag Singh under sections 108 (abetment of suicide), 351 (3) (criminal intimidation) and 3 (5) (common intention) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita. The Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD), Congress and the BJP had announced that they will jointly 'gherao' (lay siege to) CM Mann's residence to

press their demand for the arrest of Bhullar.

Leader of Opposition in the Punjab Assembly, Partap Singh Bajwa, Punjab Congress chief Amrinder Singh Raja Warring, Punjab BJP chief Sunil Jakhar, along with SAD leaders Bikram Singh Majithia and Daljit Singh Cheema were among those who took part in the protest. They were all detained by the police and later released.

It is rare for major Opposition parties in Punjab to organise a joint protest.

A large police contingent was deployed at the MLAs' Hostel here to prevent the protesters from heading towards the chief minister's residence. Barricades were also erected by the Chandigarh police. As the protesters tried to scale the barricades, police used water cannons to disperse them.



For years, the constituency remained firmly within the Congress orbit, with the Left breaching it only briefly in 1969 when the seat was rechristened as Kalighat con-

stituency. CPI(M) leader Sadhan Gupta, who became India's first visually impaired parliamentarian in 1953, won the seat during the second United Front Government of the Bangla Congress and the CPI(M).

Bhabanipur's political journey took an unusual turn in 1972 when the constituency disappeared from the electoral map following delimitation. For nearly four decades, the seat existed only in political memory.

When it was revived in the 2011 delimitation exercise,

West Bengal politics itself was undergoing a dramatic churn. That year marked the end of the Left Front's 34-year rule and the beginning of the Mamata Banerjee era.

The newly reconstituted Bhabanipur constituency quickly became intertwined with the rise of the TMC. In the first election held there in 2011, Banerjee fielded her close aide Subrata Bakshi.

Bakshi won comfortably, securing over 64 per cent of the votes and defeating CPI(M)'s Narayan Jain by nearly 50,000 votes, estab-

lishing Bhabanipur as a stronghold of the newly ascendant TMC.

Soon afterwards, Bakshi vacated the seat, allowing Banerjee — sworn in as chief minister after the TMC's landslide victory — to enter the assembly through a by-election that effectively became her electoral coronation as an MLA. Banerjee secured nearly 77 per cent of the votes and defeated CPI(M)'s Nandini Mukherjee by over 54,000 votes, firmly anchoring her political base in Bhabanipur.

Himanta, Saikia reach out to leaders threatening to contest as independents

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Guwahati

Several sitting MLAs and aspirants, who have been deprived of BJP tickets for the April 9 Assam assembly polls, have threatened to contest as Independents, with Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma and State party chief Dilip Saikia reaching out to them to calm their ire, sources said.

The recent induction of Congress leaders Pradyut Bordoloi and Bhupen Borah into the BJP and their subsequent nomination as party candidates for Dispur and Bihpuria assembly constituencies, respectively, has raised the hackles of many ticket aspirants in the party.

The most vocal protest has been in Dispur con-



stituency, where senior party leader Jayanta Das was a highly probable candidate before Bordoloi jumped into the scene. Das openly revolted against Sarma, accusing him of making the party a "Congress BJP" by bringing in his close associates from the grand old party and ignoring the old timers.

He quit the party and is likely to contest from the same constituency as an

Independent, claiming that his supporters have collected the nomination papers.

The party also denied a ticket to sitting MLA and veteran politician Atul Bora, who has represented the BJP in the constituency twice since 2016 and served two terms as an AGP leader since 1985. Bora had also announced that he was considering contesting as an Independent but the chief minister rushed to his resi-

dence to placate him, though the veteran leader did not reveal anything about his future course of action.

Discontent is high in two other constituencies — New Guwahati and Guwahati Central where veteran leaders Siddhartha Bhattacharya of the BJP and Ramendra Narayan Kalita of the AGP, both former ministers, have been denied tickets.

Bhattacharya, who was instrumental in bringing Sarma into the BJP in 2015, said that he was not angry with the party though he was reticent about his involvement in the upcoming elections. Kalita was peeved with the denial and the chief minister rushed to his residence as well to placate him.

Bhattacharya has been replaced by Samaguri's

sitting MLA Diplu Ranjan Sarma, who rushed to the senior leader's home to seek his 'blessings'. The replacement of Kalita by veteran BJP leader Vijay Gupta has also raised the hackles of a section of the constituency's electorate, as for the first time, a member of the Hindi-speaking community has been nominated for the seat.

Anger is also high in Bihpuria constituency, where Bhupen Borah has been given the seat, replacing sitting BJP MLA Amiya Kumar Bhuyan.

Bhuyan, a former All Assam Students' Union (AASU) leader, said he was considering contesting the polls as an Independent and was discussing the matter with his followers.

DMK offers 5 seats to CPI(M), Left party yet to decide

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Chennai

The ruling DMK has offered five seats to its ally, CPI (M), for the forthcoming Tamil Nadu Assembly polls, the Left party's State Secretary P Shanmugam said on Sunday.

Seat-sharing talks between the DMK and CPI (M), which have been going on for the last 20 days, saw a new development with DMK President MK Stalin personally joining the negotiations.

"... This is the first time Chief Minister (MK Stalin) took part and requested us to accept the 5 seats offered by them..," Shanmugam

told reporters. He noted that in 2021 assembly elections, the Left parties — CPI and CPI(M) — contested in six seats each.

"The CPI(M) has been asking for double digit allocation. With more parties joining the front, the DMK said providing more seats is difficult." The Chief Minister cited constraints with the expansion of the Secular Progressive Alliance.

Following the DMK's stand, the CPI(M)'s State committee met twice and decided not to insist on more than 6 seats.

"Since the current alliance has been strengthened with the arrival of new allies, we



Tamil Nadu CM MK Stalin with Left leaders

FILE PHOTO

decided not to push for more than 6 seats. Our executive committee authorised us to secure atleast 6 seats we contested in the 2021 Assembly polls," he said.

Under these circumstances, CPI (M) general sec-

retary MA Baby attended the State committee meeting on March 21, where it was decided to press for six seats.

According to Shanmugam, the Chief Minister himself reiterated the challenges of

seat allocation in a large alliance and urged the CPI(M) to remain in the front while accepting his offer.

The CPI(M) leadership has conveyed that its executive committee will meet soon and take a final decision.

"Since the Chief Minister M K Stalin himself has made a request, we have informed that the Executive Committee will meet and decide on it," he said.

Asked whether the party would consider leaving the alliance if its demand is not met, he shot back, "Why are you asking on assumption? The Marxist Communist Party will not take any such decision."

Former JD(U) leader KC Tyagi joins RLD

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Former JD(U) leader KC Tyagi on Sunday joined the Rashtriya Lok Dal (RLD), saying there is no difference between the two parties as both follow the ideals of former prime minister Chaudhary Charan Singh and socialist leader Ram Manohar Lohia.



Tyagi said he has come to the party not to become an MLA or an MP but to see RLD chief "Jayant Chaudhary becoming like (his grandfather) Chaudhary Charan Singh".

He vowed to carry forward the vision and ideals of Charan Singh during his stint in the RLD, which, like the JD(U), is an ally of the BJP and a constituent of the National Democratic Alliance (NDA).

The veteran socialist leader joined the RLD along with his supporters in the presence of the party president and Union minister Jayant Chaudhary at an event here.

Tyagi had on Tuesday announced his exit from the JD(U), without citing any reason. He was associated with the JD(U) since it came into existence in October 2003 with the merger of the Samata Party and the Janata Dal.



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Order Order

SC directs States, UTs to furnish updated details on prisons, including overcrowding



The Supreme Court has directed all the States and Union territories to furnish updated details relating to jails, including the sanctioned capacity of each prison and steps taken to check overcrowding, by May 18.

A bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta also asked the States and UTs to provide details about the number of women's prisons within their jurisdictions and the facilities available in them, including the measures taken to ensure education and overall welfare of children living with the female inmates. The bench noted that senior advocate Gaurav Agrawal, who is assisting the top court as an amicus curiae in a suo motu matter concerning inhuman conditions in jails, has drawn its attention to the fact that the statistics placed on record by the States and UTs pertain to 2023. The bench said that, having regard to the nature of issues involved and the necessity of an informed adjudicatory exercise, the availability of updated contemporaneous data was indispensable for the effective consideration of the proceedings.

"Accordingly, we deem it appropriate to direct all the States and Union territories to place on record updated and comprehensive statistics relating to all prisons situated within their respective jurisdictions," the bench said in its order passed on March 17.

It said the data shall include jail-wise capacity of each prison, total number of prisoners, percentage of overcrowding in each jail, steps proposed to address overcrowding, details of women's jails, facilities provided to women prisoners and children accompanying them (including educational and medical facilities), sanctioned strength of prison staff, existing vacancies, steps taken to fill them, along with all ancillary aspects relating to prison administration.

Vedanta moves NCLAT, challenges NCLT nod to Adani's bid for acquiring Jaiprakash Associates

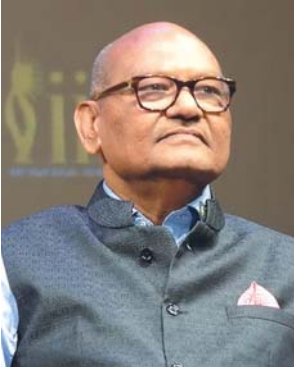
PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Business conglomerate Vedanta Group has approached the National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT), challenging the NCLT's approval to Adani Group's bid for acquiring Jaiprakash Associates Ltd for ₹14,535 crore.

Anil Agarwal-led Vedanta Group was in the race to acquire Jaiprakash Associates Ltd (JAL) through an insolvency process, but the lenders in November last year approved the resolution plan or bid of Adani Enterprises Ltd.

On March 17, the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT), Allahabad bench, approved Adani Enterprises Ltd's ₹14,535 crore bid to acquire Jaiprakash Associates Ltd (JAL) through the insolvency process.

In a regulatory filing, JAL had informed that the NCLT, Allahabad bench, has "orally pronounced an order on



Anil Agarwal and Gautam Adani



March 17, 2026" approving the resolution plan submitted by Adani Enterprises Ltd. Now, mining giant Vadanta has filed an appeal against the said NCLT order before the appellate insolvency tribunal NCLAT.

The matter is listed for hearing on Monday before a two-member bench comprising Chairperson Justice Ashok Bhushan and Member (Technical) Barun Mitra. In November last year, a Committee of Creditors (CoC)

approved the resolution plan by business tycoon Gautam Adani to acquire JAL.

Adani Enterprises had outbid Vedanta and Dalmia Bharat to win the bid for JAL. Adani got the maximum 89 per cent votes from creditors, followed by Dalmia Cement (Bharat) and Vedanta Group.

JAL, which has high-quality assets and business interests spanning real estate, cement manufacturing, hospitality, power and engineering &

construction, was admitted to the CIRP in June 2024 after it defaulted on payments of loans aggregating ₹57,185 crore.

JAL has major real estate projects like Jaypee Greens in Greater Noida, a part of Jaypee Greens Wishtown in Noida (both on the outskirts of the national capital), and the Jaypee International Sports City, located near the upcoming Jewar International Airport.

It also has three commercial/industrial office spaces in Delhi-NCR, while its hotel division has five properties in Delhi-NCR, Mussoorie, and Agra. JAL has four cement plants in Madhya Pradesh and Uttar Pradesh, and a few leased limestone mines in Madhya Pradesh.

It also has investments in subsidiaries, including Jaiprakash Power Ventures Ltd, Yamuna Expressway Tolling Ltd, Jaypee Infrastructure Development Ltd, and several other companies.

Collegium system best suited for India for time being : Former CJI BR Gavai

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

Former CJI Justice BR Gavai on Sunday said that the collegium system, at least for the time being, is the best suited for India.

He also stressed that the Government should seriously consider the national litigation policy aimed at reducing pendency at courts.

The former CJI was speaking at the valedictory session of the Supreme Court Bar Association's (SCBA) first National Conference — 2026 titled "Reimagining Judicial Governance: Strengthening Institutions for Democratic Justice."

"An issue was raised with regard to the functioning of the collegium. I won't say that the collegium system is a foolproof system. There can't

be a perfect system. Every system has its advantages and disadvantages. But after working for so many years, I find that the collegium system, at least for the time being, is the best suited for our country," Gavai said.

He said the collegium doesn't work arbitrarily. The names of the judges are recommended by the Chief Justice of the High Court and the collegium of the two most senior judges, and thereafter, it goes to the Central Government.

"The inputs of the central Government, the intelligence department and everybody are gathered, and thereafter, the Supreme Court Collegium takes a final decision. And even after the names are sent, if the Government, the executive have any issues, those issues are addressed to

the collegium. The collegium considers those issues, and thereafter, it takes a final call," he added.

Speaking about the huge gap between the sanctioned strength and the number of appointments of the High Court judges, the former CJI said, the judgement of the Supreme Court, on more than one occasion, has stated that, on the second reiteration, by the collegium, the executives are bound to make the appointment.

"But I'm sorry to say that there are various names which, even on the second recommendation, are not yet cleared by the executive. So, it's not a blame game, but I must flag this issue," he said.

The executive needs to consider whether they are bound by the two judgements of the Supreme Court,



Former CJI Justice BR Gavai

which say that on a second recommendation, the appointments are required to be made, he further added.

Noting that he has always maintained that High Court judges are not inferior to Supreme Court judges, Justice Gavai while speaking on the transfer of judges, said that

both are constitutional functionaries, but certain issues require transfers to be made.

"I ask a question if a particular judge defies the judgments of the Supreme Court on more than one occasion, and takes a view, contrary to the views explained by the Supreme Court in a particu-

lar matter, should the collegium remain idle or take corrective steps? Since, Bar is the mother of the judges, I must put this issue with the Bar," he added.

Stating that as a judge he has always been in favour of maintaining a balance between the protection of the environment and sustainable development, the former CJI said, that the courts do not interfere in environmental matters just for the sake of interference, an as a matter of fact, it is because of the judgements of the court that the forest in the country are protected.

"It is because of the judgement of the Supreme Court that the issues with regard to pollution have been addressed. But I am not willing to accept the criticism that, in such matters, the

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Bengaluru

CJI Justice Surya Kant has said that Artificial Intelligence (AI) must be integrated into the judicial system in a manner that strengthens the institution without undermining its core functions. In his inaugural address at a one-day seminar on "Artificial Intelligence — Prevention and Resolution of Disputes" at the Karnataka Judicial Academy, on Saturday, he said, "AI should assist in handling large volumes of data and records, identifying patterns, and reducing procedural delays".

However, he said, "It must not encroach upon the core judicial function of delivering judgments," according to a release. The Chief Justice cautioned that allowing AI tools to dominate decision-making could compromise transparency and accountability within the justice delivery system. He stressed that the final stage of adjudication must remain in human hands.

"The final stage of the judicial process, pronouncement of judgments, must remain firmly in human hands," he said, adding that judges must rely on their reasoning, experience and analytical abilities while delivering verdicts.

Emphasising the role of technology as an enabler, he said AI should function only as a tool. "AI should function only



CJI Justice Surya Kant

as a tool or pathway, while the direction must always be determined by human intellect," he said. The event was organised in collaboration with the UIA India Chapter, the Bar Association of India and the National Law School of India University.

Speaking on the occasion, Karnataka High Court Chief Justice Vibhu Bakhru raised concerns about the evolving role of AI in the judiciary, questioning whether it would remain an aid to human decision-making or become a substitute that diminishes the role of judges. He also highlighted both opportunities and risks, noting that AI can

enable predictive analysis of disputes and improve efficiency, while AI-supported online dispute resolution platforms can facilitate faster and cost-effective disposal of cases.

Stressing safeguards, he said judicial independence, transparency and legality must remain paramount, and the use of AI must be guided by clearly defined principles.

Bar Association of India President Prashant Kumar said AI has enabled rapid translation of court judgments into local languages, improving accessibility for people in rural areas and aiding lawyers in communicating with clients.



Par panel seeks details on activating Lokpal's inquiry, prosecution wings

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Parliamentary Committee has sought details of what all is being done to fully operationalise the inquiry and prosecution wings of the Lokpal, over a decade after a law governing it was enacted.

The law governing the anti-corruption ombudsman — The Lokpal and Lokayuktas Act 2013 — came into force on January 1, 2014. However, it began functioning only on March 27, 2019, following the appointment of its chairperson and members.

To discharge its statutory functions, Section 11 of the Act obligates the Lokpal to constitute an inquiry wing to be headed by a director of inquiry for conducting a preliminary inquiry into corruption-related offences.

The Lokpal Act also has a provision for the constitution of a prosecution wing headed by the 'director of prosecution' for the prosecution of public servants.

In its latest report, the Department-related Parliamentary Standing Committee on Personnel, Public Grievances, Law and Justice noted that the appointment of the Director of Inquiry and staffing of the inquiry



wing in accordance with the approved organogram is still in process.

The committee, therefore, desires to be apprised of the present status of appointment of the director and the steps taken to operationalise the inquiry wing in its full statutory form, while ensuring coordination with existing investigative agencies, it said.

The panel, in its 160th report, said that the prosecution wing of the Lokpal has been formally constituted through an order dated June 6, 2025.

The committee noted that, at present, matters relating to prosecution are being handled through the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), which has its own prosecution mechanism.

"While taking note of the constitution of the Prosecution Wing, the committee desires to be apprised of the present stage of operationalisation of the prosecution wing and the proposed roadmap for making it fully functional in accordance with the statutory framework," the report said.

As regards notification of a special court under Section 35 of the Act, the panel said that the matter has been taken up with the High Court of Delhi and is being actively pursued.

It said, presently, cases are being tried by special judges notified under the Prevention of Corruption Act, 1988, pursuant to a sanction granted by the Lokpal. "The Committee desires to be apprised of the present status of consulta-

tions with the High Court and the expected timeline for notification of a dedicated special court under Section 35 of the Act," said the committee's report on Demands for Grants (2026-27) of the Department of Personnel and Training (DoPT).

Citing details of corruption complaints, the panel said that a total of 318 complaints were registered during 2024-25 (till December 31, 2025). Of these, 288 were disposed of.

The Lokpal had received 292 and 166 corruption complaints during 2024-25 and 2023-24, respectively.

The committee recommended that the staffing position of the Lokpal secretariat be reviewed in light of the rising trend in complaints and inquiry activity.

"Vacancies in key operational and support divisions may be filled expeditiously, and necessary coordination with the concerned authorities may be undertaken to ensure that adequate manpower is made available to enable the Lokpal to discharge its statutory functions efficiently and without interruption," the report said.

Of the sanctioned strength of 65, there are 24 vacant positions in the anti-corruption residency, according to the report.

NCLAT exemption to 50 IL&FS companies from CSR obligations

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Insolvency appellate tribunal (NCLAT) has exempted IL&FS Group companies — categorised as 'red' and 'amber' — from Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) on account of interest expenses accrued on their loan amount.

The order will benefit around 50 'amber' and 'red' companies of the debt-ridden IL&FS Group, which are protected under the moratorium granted by the NCLAT from its order dated October 15, 2018.

242(2) (m) of the Companies Act in its order passed earlier this month. "We find that sufficient cause has been shown in the application for allowing the prayer made by the Applicant to dispense with the requirement to undertake spending the necessary amount on CSR activities under Section 135(5) of the Companies Act, 2013 from Red/Amber Companies," said NCLAT.

Section 135(5) of the Companies Act mandates that the board of every company shall ensure that the company spends, in every financial year, at least



These 'red' and 'amber' entities have not been accruing interest on their outstanding debts, resulting in such companies showing notional profits in their books of accounts under Section 198 of the Companies Act.

Such notional profits have led to such companies liable to comply with CSR obligations under Section 135 of the Act.

IL&FS Group moved an application last year before NCLAT to correct this, seeking exemption for entities from compliance with CSR obligations. A notice was issued to the Government on the application by IL&FS. A two-member bench, which also comprised Chairperson Justice Ashok Bhushan, granted the waiver using its discretionary power under Sections 241(2) and

2 per cent of the average net profits of the company made during the three immediately preceding financial years.

The section applies to every company having a net worth of ₹500 crore or more, or turnover of ₹1,000 crore or more, or a net profit of ₹5 crore.

As per the roadmap, IL&FS Group companies have been divided into three categories — green, amber and red — based on their respective financial positions.

Companies under the green category are those that continue to meet their payment obligations.

Red entities are those failing to meet debt obligations even to senior secured creditors, while amber entities can only meet operational expenses and senior secured debt payments, lacking capacity for others.



Editor's
TAKE

Preserving Bhagirathi: India's ecological test case

Bhagirathi is the source of a river that sustains millions. The challenge is, if India can pursue development without eroding it ecological foundation

The Bhagirathi Eco-Sensitive Zone (BESZ) is tucked in the Himalayan ecosystem and is one of the most fragile systems we have. It is highly vulnerable to even slight changes in climate or human intervention. Even limited construction and human activity can create havoc in this highly sensitive zone. Despite this, massive construction projects are underway, hundreds of dams are being built, and infrastructure expansion is seriously undermining the ecological integrity of the Himalayas.

It is not that the risks are not evaluated, but they have been sidelined in the name of development and progress. And the people have paid the price for it. Flash floods, landslides and forest fires have taken a heavy toll on human life and property. In this context, the recent intervention by Union Environment Minister Bhupender Yadav on the need for "stakeholder convergence" in the Bhagirathi Eco-Sensitive Zone is both timely and necessary. The Bhagirathi basin-where Ganga originates - is not merely a geographic entity is the basis of Indian civilisation. If anything goes wrong, it will affect the entire northern India, so preserving it is not just about environmental concerns but a larger issue of saving the lifeline of the nation. It is a national imperative.

The Bhagirathi Eco-Sensitive Zone (BESZ) is located in fragile Himalayan terrain with rich biodiversity and has high hydrological importance. This feeds one of the world's most densely populated river systems. Any disturbance here-be it deforestation, unregulated construction, or hydropower overreach can have a detrimental effect on millions of people who depend on the Ganga for water, agriculture, and livelihood. The present state of the BESZ is not a happy one and is constantly under strain. The push for infrastructure and economic development is not in keeping with environmental prudence. Many projects have been undertaken without adequate cumulative impact assessments.

At the same time, conservation cannot be pursued in isolation from local aspirations. The communities inhabiting the Bhagirathi valley face real challenges-limited access to services, economic constraints, and vulnerability to climate change. Stalling all projects will risk alienating these stakeholders and undermining conservation goals.

This is where the idea of "stakeholder convergence" becomes crucial. It implies genuine participation of local communities, scientists, and civil society in decision-making. Indeed, the BESZ must be governed by robust, science-based frameworks. Comprehensive cumulative impact assessments should guide all major interventions.

The monitoring committees must be empowered with real authority, technical expertise, and transparency in functioning. Sustainable livelihood - Eco-tourism, organic farming, and value-added forest produce can align economic incentives with ecological preservation. Local communities should be treated as custodians of India's ecological heritage not as encroachers!



ANIL
BHATT

In the 1991 Gulf War, what the US-led coalition forces attacked near Baghdad, claiming it was a biological weapons laboratory, turned out to be a baby milk factory. The incident became a prominent example of the "intelligence controversies" about Iraq possessing weapons of mass destruction (WMD) and made it more difficult to differentiate between civilian dual-use infrastructure and hidden weapons production.

In 2003, the US attacked Iraq based on largely false assumptions that Saddam Hussein possessed stockpiles of WMD, held active biological/chemical weapons programs, and maintained ties to terrorist organisations like Al-Qaeda. Investigations after the invasion revealed that these assumptions were based on flawed or misrepresented intelligence, and no active WMD programs or links to the 9/11 attacks were found.

On February 28, 2026, following failed negotiations, claims of imminent threats, and Iran's alleged continued efforts to build a nuclear weapon, the US and Israel launched "Operation Epic Fury"-the name selected by Trump-a series of coordinated military attacks on Iran, aiming to dismantle its nuclear and ballistic missile programs, prevent regional attacks, and potentially force regime change. For twenty days since it began, this largely "troop-less" war has amounted to missile strikes and aerial bombardment, causing significant civilian casualties, including at least 165 schoolgirls and injuring many others in Iran.

The United States deployed a formidable array of advanced weaponry. These included Tomahawk cruise missiles launched from naval platforms, GBU-28 bunker-buster bombs targeting fortified underground facilities, and Joint Direct Attack Munition (JDAM) kits converting conventional bombs into precision-guided weapons. B-2 stealth bombers were used against hardened targets, while Hellfire "Ninja" missiles enabled highly precise strikes. Ground-based systems such as HIMARS were also reportedly employed.

Israel complemented these capabilities with its own advanced systems, including Delilah stand-off missiles and Rampage supersonic air-to-surface missiles. SPICE guidance kits enhanced strike accuracy even in GPS-denied environments. Its F-35I "Adir" stealth fighters and F-15I "Ra'am" strike aircraft enabled deep-penetration and heavy payload missions.

In twenty days, U.S. and Israeli forces have reportedly struck over 15,000 targets across Iran during an escalating conflict, with the Pentagon reporting over 7,000-7,800 targets hit by U.S.

When the oceans bleed: Hidden war on water



RACHNA
LAKHPATRI

2ND OPINION

Diplomacy fills the headlines. The real price is being paid in silence - at the bottom of our oceans, in the rivers we drink from, in the skies our children will breathe. There is a conversation happening in every war room in the world right now. It involves maps, missiles, and men in suits who speak the language of strategy with the ease of breathing. What no one is putting on the table - what no one has the appetite to discuss - is what is quietly dying while they talk. Not just the soldiers. Not just the civilians. But water. The very thing that made this planet worth fighting over in the first place.

We speak of wars in terms of land gained and lives lost. But no map ever marks the aquifer poisoned by depleted uranium, or the seabed cratered by bomb blasts, or the coastline choked in oil from a vessel that became



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what comes out the other end is safe enough to call water? We have the technology. We will build the filters. But there is something deeply broken about a civilisation that destroys a resource with one hand and engineers a solution with the other, and calls that progress. Water is not a resource. It is a relationship - between the land and the sky, between the living and those who come after. Every war that poisons it is not just a crime against nature. It is a crime against time itself. And time, unlike a ceasefire, cannot be negotiated.

The writer is a freelancer writes on development, social and gender issues

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Rupee debate: Then and now

There is nothing wrong in questioning the trajectory of the Indian Rupee (INR) from the tenure of Dr. Manmohan Singh to the present government led by Narendra Modi. When Mr. Modi assumed office as Prime Minister in 2014, the exchange rate stood at approximately 1 USD = ₹58.58. As of 20 March 2026, it has depreciated to around 1 USD = ₹93.49. It is worth recalling that during his tenure as Chief Minister of Gujarat, Mr. Modi was a vocal critic of the UPA government over the falling rupee, which declined from about ₹45 to beyond ₹60. In his speech on 20 August 2013, he remarked: "We never thought such a huge economic mess would be created. It's a grave concern. There is a lack of confidence in the leadership. It is the country's misfortune that the leadership only cares about staying in power and not about national security or strengthening the rupee." He went further to link the weakening rupee to the government's credibility, even drawing comparisons between the currency's decline and the age of the then Prime Minister. Today, while some argue that global factors—particularly the strengthening of the US dollar—have contributed to the rupee's depreciation, and that it has performed relatively better than several other currencies, the reality remains that the rupee has significantly weakened over time.

BIDYUT KUMAR CHATTERJEE | FARIDABAD

Rising input costs add to farmers' woes

The sharp 25 per cent rise in pesticide prices amid the ongoing West Asia conflict has dealt a severe blow to already distressed farmers. Erratic and unseasonal weather has damaged standing crops, while soaring input costs have made fresh sowing increasingly unaffordable. This double burden is pushing farmers deeper into financial uncertainty. The situation becomes even more alarming when market prices collapse.

Farmers are often forced to sell their produce—such as potatoes in Punjab—at as low as ₹1 per kg, far below the promised Minimum Support Price (MSP). Such distress sales leave them trapped in a cycle of debt and despair, eroding both their income and morale.

The government must step in with urgent measures, including subsidies on essential inputs, assured procurement at MSP, and direct financial assistance.

Expanding crop insurance coverage and strengthening storage infrastructure are equally critical to protect farmers from both market and climate shocks. While farmers can explore diversification and cooperative models to improve their bargaining power, these efforts alone are insufficient.

Without strong and timely state support, their very survival remains at stake.

RS NARULA | PATIALA

Explore new oil & gas wells

With the Middle East conflict showing no signs of resolution and tensions between the United States and Iran reaching dangerous levels, India must urgently reassess its energy strategy. A renewed focus on geological surveys by ONGC across the country, along with exploration of new onshore and offshore oil and gas fields, is essential. India's vast Exclusive Economic Zone (EEZ), spanning about 2.37 million sq km, and its extended continental shelf of nearly 3.2 million sq km together provide a strong resource base for such efforts. In the short term, measures to curb petrol and diesel consumption are necessary to reduce dependence on imports. The Middle East has long remained a volatile region, and prolonged conflict could severely disrupt global supply chains of crude oil and gas. The experience of other ongoing conflicts highlights how fragile peace efforts can be. India must therefore move decisively towards energy self-reliance by expanding domestic production while simultaneously accelerating the transition to renewable energy sources. Strengthening both conventional and alternative energy capacities is the only sustainable way to secure the nation's future in an increasingly uncertain geopolitical landscape.

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TAMIL NADU'S POLITICAL MATURITY BEYOND CINEMA STEREOTYPES

Mr. Kiran Rijiju's recent remark on Tamil society—that Tamilians excel in science yet emotionally submit to film heroes—does not fully reflect reality. Tamil Nadu's progress is rooted in sustained investments in education, skill development, and healthcare, upheld by successive governments regardless of political affiliation. Despite limited natural resources and dependence on other states for water, Tamil Nadu consistently ranks high on development indices and maintains a strong industrial and infrastructure base. Even the Madras port, though not a natural harbour, remains a significant asset. Development, though varying in pace across regimes, has always remained a priority, making the state a major source of technocrats and skilled manpower. The claim regarding blind devotion to film heroes also

requires correction. Only M.G. Ramachandran and J. Jayalalithaa successfully transitioned from cinema to political power. Several others—such as Sivaji Ganesan, Vijayakanth, Karthik, and Sarathkumar—failed despite political attempts. Currently, Vijay's political foray appears uncertain, marked by limited clarity in ideology and crisis management. Public gatherings often reflect cinematic appeal rather than political endorsement. Tamil Nadu's electorate is politically aware and discerning. While alliances shift, voters do not easily conflate celebrity with leadership. Political parties, too, remain cautious in their strategies, reflecting a mature and pragmatic political culture that resists simplistic generalisations.

A G RAJMOHAN, | ANANTAPUR

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Collateral crisis: The unseen global fallout

What began as a seemingly contained regional confrontation has rapidly spiralled into a global crisis, sending shockwaves far beyond the battlefield. From grounded flights and disrupted trade routes to surging fuel prices and rising household costs, the ripple effects are being felt in homes, markets, and airports across continents



HEMANGI SINHA

What began as a regional confrontation has quickly become a global shockwave, unsettling air travel, energy supplies, trade routes, and the daily routines of millions far from the battlefield. What on the surface seems to be a far-off geopolitical battle is really changing the everyday-increasing the cost of food and gasoline, postponing travel, upsetting livelihoods, and adding uncertainty to homes across continents. The effects of conflict are no longer limited to national boundaries in today's linked globe; instead, they spread across human networks, financial institutions, and supply chains, subtly altering how people move, work, and live.

Aviation and Diaspora Disruption:

International air travel has completely stopped. Early in March, Gulf hubs, including Dubai, the world's busiest international airport, were closed, leaving "tens of thousands" of travellers stranded. "Over 3,400 flights were cancelled" at key Middle Eastern airports in the first weekend alone, according to travel industry analysts. Routes operated by Emirates and Qatar Airways to Ethiad were suspended, and all flights were halted at major hubs, including Abu Dhabi and Doha. In an effort to evacuate their residents, governments from Britain, France, India, and other countries hired special evacuation aircraft from the area. For instance, by early March, the U.S. State Department claimed to have evacuated "thousands" of Americans from the Gulf using "over a dozen" charter planes. In reality, regular travellers have taken extreme actions. To attend her brother's wedding in Europe, a Dubai expat travelled across multiple countries over 33 hours, passing through Saudi Arabia and Oman. Others eagerly awaited the resumption of regular flights in hotels or airport lounges.

Energy Shock and Inflation

The fighting has caused petrol and oil prices to soar, directly affecting consumers. In the weeks after the strikes, Brent crude increased by almost 40%, from about \$70 to over \$100 per barrel. Fears of Hormuz interruptions caused European natural gas to soar by almost 38% in early March, momentarily



pushing Brent above \$120. Citizens globally should be cautioned that prices may rise significantly higher, even to \$130, if tensions continue. Everyday expenses are already being impacted by these increases. In only a few weeks, petrol prices in the United States increased by more than 21%. Even non-fuel products are impacted since over 40% of crude oil is utilised for transportation and chemicals; basic products like clothes, soap, and furniture, all of which are derived from petroleum, now need to be created with more expensive materials. Similar increases in heating fuel and fertiliser have put food prices and utility costs at risk.

Shipping and Trade Delays

Global trade has been hampered, as has energy. About 20% of the world's oil regularly passes through the Strait of Hormuz, a narrow chokepoint that has effectively been sealed. Insurance companies have discontinued "war-risk" coverage for Persian Gulf lines, and at least 150 tankers are currently stranded off the strait due to drone and missile strikes. The cost of goods has increased dramatically as a result. Since the start of the war, air cargo rates from South Asia to Europe have increased by nearly 70 per cent (from roughly \$2.57 to \$4.37 per kilogram) as freighters add fuel stops and avoid ports closed by the war, such as Dubai. The cost of sea freight has also increased; certain tanker routes report rates that are more than three times higher than before the war. In actuality, this implies that most imported items are more expensive and require longer wait times. Imports of food, mechanical components, and electronics

must now pay these additional transportation expenses. Global inflationary pressure is the result, particularly in nations that rely heavily on imports.

Financial and Economic Ripples

Currencies and financial markets are also responding. While the currencies of countries that buy oil have declined, safe-haven flows have bolstered the US dollar and gold. The rupee fell to an all-time low (around 92-93 per dollar) while Brent increased by over 40%. Other Asian currencies, including the won, baht, and peso, are under pressure due to widening trade imbalances, while Turkey's lira dropped to an all-time low (about 44 to the dollar). Fears of stagflation have caused stock indexes to decline, such as the Sensex in India and other Asian bourses. It has been noted that central banks are cautious because rising oil prices are putting fresh pressure on inflation projections, which may delay rate cuts or lead to further tightening. In many nations, borrowing and living expenses have increased for consumers and companies; mortgages, loans, and savings rates may also change. In summary, while prices remain higher than anticipated, global growth may stall.

Human and Social Costs

Individual suffering is a result of these macro shocks. During Ramadan, many travellers from South and Southeast Asia and beyond experienced flight cancellations or were left stranded. Distress calls from migrant workers and families stranded between shuttered airports have increased, accord-

ing to embassies. There are reports of terrified pilgrims and vacationers waiting at airports, unsure whether they will make it home in time for Ramadan or other holidays. Everyday activities are affected, including missed doctor's visits, postponed business travel and weddings, and lost pay. In one striking story, a Lebanese woman "risked her life to get it" by cooking chicken beneath a tent for her family's Ramadan fast in the face of sniper fire since she was unable to get to a market safely. Religious and cultural customs, including holiday gatherings, Umrah pilgrimages, and parent visits, have been disrupted. As the typical freedom to travel or simply leave home disappears, there is an increasing psychological cost: people express worry, insomnia, and a sense of helplessness.

Political and Strategic Shifts

The response from the world's leaders has been profound and extensive. The change has happened quickly in Washington: U.S. officials said that sanctions on Iranian oil may be lifted, releasing some 140 million barrels of crude onto global markets to lower prices. In an effort to safeguard oil shipments, the United States also said that its Navy will escort commercial ships through the Hormuz Strait "as soon as reasonable." Japan and other allies have been commended by President Trump for "stepping up" on energy security. Europe, on the other hand, has openly called for moderation and is discussing ways to stabilise markets (some EU countries are even considering lifting sanctions on Russian energy to secure alternative oil supplies). In the meantime,

nations like India are juggling their priorities: to guarantee energy supply and remove its sizable expat population-more than 3.5 million Indians reside in the UAE alone-New Delhi has discreetly taken action. Diplomatically, long-standing ties are being put to the test. While G7 partners work together on defence and reserve releases, disagreements have surfaced about penalties and crisis management. This battle has already expanded, presenting the possibility of a protracted, multipolar conflict due to regional proxies (in Syria, Yemen, and Afghanistan) and rivalry (Pakistan-Afghanistan tensions, proxy conflicts).

Impact on culture & environment

The ramifications go beyond the realm of economics. The Middle East's \$367 billion annual tourism economy has all but van-

ished. According to one projection, the area may see 23-38 million fewer visitors this year, resulting in \$34-56 billion in lost revenue. Reservations in the UAE were already drastically down; a travel CEO reported a "big collapse in bookings" for March and Easter as tourists went to Portugal, Italy, and Greece. Airstrikes have reportedly destroyed at least 56 museums and monuments in Iran, including UNESCO-listed palaces and squares. UNESCO has expressed serious concern about hundreds of historical sites in the area. Attacks on pipelines and oil fields locally run the danger of causing minor spills and air pollution that might degrade air and marine quality. The environmental cost of our energy habits is paradoxically highlighted by this crisis: more stranded tankers increase the risk of spills; detoured aircraft use more fuel; and short-term fixes (such as using heavier fuels or postponing climate measures) may undo sustainability gains. This is "the worst disruption to global energy supplies in history," it will ultimately serve as a stark reminder of the necessity of replacing fossil fuels.

Looking Ahead

A Vulnerable New Order, In the end, the "collateral crisis" highlights how intertwined and vulnerable the globe has grown. What started as a local conflict swiftly sent shockwaves through markets, supply chains, and everyday life worldwide. Energy and trade policy have to change drastically. The conflict has forced nations to "rethink ways to reduce long-term dependence on oil and gas." Recently, countries have been discussing increased fuel stocks and alternative pipeline or shipping routes, while nuclear power (in Japan, Europe, and Taiwan) and renewable energy have returned to the forefront. According to one insider, "energy security has never been as acute as now," thus no international leader is taking Gulf oil for granted. This entails some unpleasant realisations for common folks. Even after a truce, cultural losses, travel anxiety, and the expense of living pinch may continue. It is believed that the long-term lesson will be resilience-diversifying energy and trade partners, so that regular households won't be left to suffer the most when the next local dispute breaks out. However, homes around the world will soon have to prepare for higher costs, delayed deliveries, and anxiety. Our strong reliance on single commerce and energy routes now has serious social and political repercussions, as one expert said, and the effects of this shock will be felt for years.

Balidan Diwas: Remembering the legacy of Bhagat Singh



RAHUL KAUSHIK

On March 23, each year, India pauses to remember not just the execution of Bhagat Singh, but the meaning of sacrifice itself. His Balidan Diwas is not a ritual of mourning; it is a reminder of a life lived with clarity, discipline, and an uncompromising sense of duty toward the nation. At just twenty-three, Bhagat Singh did not merely face death; he walked toward it with conviction, having already defined the purpose of his life.

To understand the significance of this day, one must look beyond the dramatic final moments in Lahore Central Jail and examine the deeper forces that shaped him. Bhagat Singh was not an accidental revolutionary. He was the product of a cultural and intellectual environment rooted in the ideas of the Arya Samaj, which had a strong presence in Punjab during his formative years. His family was deeply influenced by Swami Dayanand Saraswati's teachings, where nationalism was inseparable from civilizational pride and moral discipline.

His education in Dayanand Anglo-Vedic institutions reinforced these values. These were not mere schools; they were spaces where young minds were trained to internalise courage, service, and respect for India's ancient heritage. Bhagat Singh's nationalism, therefore, did not emerge out of reaction to colonial rule alone. It was rooted in a long-standing belief that the nation was a living entity deserving total commitment.

The emotional and intellectual turning point of his childhood came after the Jallianwala Bagh massacre. The young Bhagat Singh visited the site, collected soil soaked in the blood of martyrs, and preserved it with reverence. This act, often remembered symbolically, reflected something deeper, and that is his early acceptance of sacrifice as sacred. The Arya Samaj's interpretation of 'yajna' as self-offering for societal welfare found a living embodiment in him.

By 1923, Bhagat Singh had already chosen his path. He openly declared that he would dedicate his life to Bharat Mata instead of pursuing personal ambitions like marriage or career. This decision was not driven by impulse but by a conscious rejection of individual comfort in favour of collective duty. His life from that point onward was an unfolding of that commitment.



This clarity of purpose became most visible during his trial. When his father attempted to seek clemency, Bhagat Singh opposed it firmly. He believed that asking for mercy would dilute the moral foundation of his struggle. He chose principle over survival, demonstrating that for him, freedom was not negotiable at any cost.

As 23 March 1931 approached, the atmosphere across the country was charged with emotion. Appeals, protests, and public pressure attempted to halt the execution. Yet, Bhagat Singh remained unmoved. He had already accepted death as the final step in his commitment. For him, martyrdom was not an end but the completion of a promise he had made years earlier.

Even in his final days, his actions carried meaning. His request to eat bread prepared by a safai karamachari in jail was a deliberate statement against social hierarchies. At a time when caste-based discrimination was deeply entrenched, this simple act conveyed a powerful message that dignity is inherent and not determined by birth. Equality, in his understanding, was integral to national strength.

His intellectual life in prison further reflects the depth of his character. Bhagat Singh spent his last month's reading extensively, engaging with texts that dealt with philosophy, politics, and history.

Among these, the Bhagavad Gita stands out for its resonance with his life. The Gita's central idea of 'nishkama karma' i.e. performing one's duty without attachment to outcomes, finds a clear reflection in his choices. He did not act for recognition or reward; he acted because he believed it was his duty.

The Gita also teaches that death in the path of righteousness is not defeat. This idea aligns closely with Bhagat Singh's acceptance

of martyrdom. His composure, clarity, and absence of fear in the face of execution reflect a mind anchored in conviction rather than circumstance.

His journey was not solitary. Alongside him stood Shivaram Rajguru and Sukhdev Thapar, who shared his commitment to sacrifice and duty. Together, they represented a generation that saw freedom not as an abstract goal but as a responsibility requiring total dedication. Their unity was rooted in shared values, not merely shared circumstances.

Bhagat Singh's intellectual influences extended beyond immediate circles. He was deeply impacted by the writings of Vinayak Damodar Savarkar, particularly the interpretation of the 1857 uprising as a national war of independence. Bhagat Singh understood the power of ideas in shaping action. He ensured that such works were circulated widely, believing that history could inspire future generations.

His writings and jail diary reflect a mind that rejected blind sacrifice. He believed that sacrifice must be purposeful, directed toward achieving a larger objective. This distinction is crucial in understanding his legacy. He was not driven by emotion alone but by a strategic and disciplined approach to revolution.

On Balidan Diwas, what is remembered is not just the act of hanging three young men in Lahore Jail, but the culmination of a life built on conviction.

Bhagat Singh's martyrdom was not an isolated moment of bravery. It was the flowering of values cultivated over years - discipline, equality, intellectual rigour, and an unwavering sense of duty.

The relevance of 23 March lies in its ability to confront superficial understandings of patriotism. Bhagat Singh's life does not allow for comfortable narratives. It demands an engagement with the idea of sacrifice as responsibility, not spectacle. It forces a recognition that freedom was not granted but earned through lives that refused compromise.

Balidan Diwas, therefore, is not about remembrance alone. It is about confronting the standards set by those who chose duty over self, principle over survival, and action over hesitation. Bhagat Singh's legacy continues to stand as a measure of commitment that is unyielding, disciplined, and rooted in a vision that extended far beyond his own lifetime.



HARISH JAIN

Bhagat Singh, Sukhdev, and Rajguru remain among the most luminous names in India's struggle for freedom. Bhagat Singh, born in 1907 into a politically conscious Sikh family in Punjab, emerged in his early twenties as the most articulate voice of revolutionary nationalism, combining daring action with rare intellectual depth. Sukhdev Thapar, his close comrade from Lahore, was the disciplined organiser behind much of the Hindustan Socialist Republican Association's work in north India. Shivaram Hari Rajguru, the youngest of the three, was remembered by contemporaries for his courage, marksmanship, and unwavering loyalty to the revolutionary cause. On 23 March 1931, all three were executed in Lahore Central Jail. Their martyrdom transformed them into enduring figures in India's political memory.

Among the many documents associated with their final days, one stands apart with unusual force: the demand that they should not be hanged like criminals but shot like soldiers. This text is generally believed to be a single letter written by Bhagat Singh and his comrades shortly before their execution. A closer examination of the historical record, however, suggests that it emerged through two related communications written in the last weeks before their death-one addressed to the Jail Superintendent and another to the Governor of Punjab.

The first communication appears to have been addressed to the Jail Superintendent, the immediate authority through whom prisoners were required to communicate with higher officials. In it, the revolutionaries made an argument that was both simple and devastating. They had been convicted under the charge of waging war against the King-Emperor. If that charge was to be taken seriously, they argued, they could not be treated as ordinary criminals. They were political combatants engaged in a struggle between an enslaved nation and an imperial power. As such, they should be treated as soldiers and executed by firing squad. This was not theatrical rhetoric. It was a deliberate political intervention. By invoking the very language used by the colonial tribunal, Bhagat Singh and his comrades turned the logic of the state against itself. If the state insisted that they had waged war, it had already admitted the political nature of their actions.

The second and better-known letter, addressed to the Governor of Punjab, carried this argument further. Here, the revolutionaries made their position unmistakable. They did not beg for pardon. They did not seek commutation of their sentence.



SINCE 1865

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15-YEAR WINDOW

India has a narrow 15-20-year window to enjoy the fruits of the existing demographic dividends. After the early 2040s, the working-age cohort between 15 and 59 years, which constitutes two-thirds of the current population, will “peak... after which the labour force will contract, and dependency ratios will climb. The next 15-20 years represent the final phase of India’s youth bulge entering the workforce.” This is a stark warning that emanates from the recent research study posted on orfonline.org. “With the demographic window closing, there is a narrow and urgent opportunity to ensure that this final wave of new workers is effectively absorbed, particularly into sectors that require advanced and interdisciplinary skills,” states the report. If this workforce is equipped with the right skills, good health, and gainful jobs in high-value sectors, it can serve as a lever to energise growth. If India misses this train, or aircraft, it will miss the bus to transition to a high-income economy.

At present, the World Bank classifies India as a lower-middle-income economy “with a median age under 30.” Despite frenetic growth, being the fastest-growing major economy, and becoming the fourth-largest economy, India can fall into the middle-income trap. This is because most emerging nations escape poverty, and emerge as middle-income ones, but struggle to reach the high-income status. Indeed, as per the World Bank, such stragglers-stragglers experience long periods of stagnation or lower growths. This happens because the earlier drivers of growth such as abundance of low-cost labour, capital formation, and export expansion begins to “exhaust.” In India’s case, the problems are acute as it never became an export-led economy like the Asian Tigers, China, or even Japan in the last century. Hence, if it loses the advantage of abundant and cheap workforce, which it may enjoy till the early 2040s, the momentum will be lost. Since 1990, according to the World Bank, only 34 nations have broken the middle-income trap.

Of course, the prime reason for the changing demographics within two decades stems from declines in the fertility rates “across regions, income brackets, and religious groups. Data from the National Fertility and Health Surveys show that India’s Total fertility Rate dropped to 2 in 2019-21 from 3.39 in 1990-92.” Since the replacement threshold is 2.1, the population degrowth will become visible in 15-20 years. According to the study, “the ramifications are sweeping: School enrollments will taper, the working-age population will peak within decades, and the share of elderly citizens will accelerate. The Indian policy-making machine must study the various first-, second-, and third-order effects of this drop to mitigate their negative consequences.” Coupled with the economic implications of the middle-income trap, the impact can be colossal, and derail the Indian economic gravity train.

Rising dependency ratios in the 2040s will strain public policies and public finances. The ratio will shoot up from 16 per cent to 30 per cent by 2050. For every three working-age persons, there will be one above 60 years, which will reshape “intergenerational economics. Without adequate pension systems, insurance coverage, and preventive healthcare, the working-age population will bear rising fiscal and caregiving burdens, heightening intergenerational inequity. Investing early in care systems and productivity-enhancing health infrastructure is essential to sustaining social contracts, and political stability.” The use of technology will be crucial to evolve solutions, and handle the future challenges. As the study finds, “Technology can be an important differentiator in the delivery of these services. Health tech, telemedicine, and diagnostics driven by AI, and advancements in biotech and materials can ensure medical services at scale.” Hence, the current moves to make both healthcare and insurance access to the entire population, including villages, are notable.

Across the states in the north, west, and south, the fertility rates are below the national average of 2, except Rajasthan, where it is incrementally up at 2.01. In the central region, only Uttar Pradesh has a high fertility rate of 2.35. Only in the east, Bihar (fertility rate of 3) and Jharkhand (2.3) are above the national average, and West Bengal and Odisha are below it. “This divergence implies that India’s demographic shift will occur in an uneven manner. Some states... will face ageing burdens and shrinking labour forces by the 2030s. These states have high per-capita incomes, and higher levels of industrialisation and urbanisation. They also face a higher degree of immigration from labour-surplus states,” explains the study. The states that will generate young workers well into the 2040s depend on agriculture, and rural sectors. At present, they migrate to the west and south but grab low-income jobs. For them to add to productive India implies higher and better education, and a new set of skills.

In a decade or two, the dynamics of ‘silver economy,’ or one tuned to the demands and needs of the elderly, will kick in. “Younger households with fewer children will spend more... on education, health, and enrichment. At the same time, the ageing households will direct a higher share... towards medical insurance, preventive healthcare, geriatric care and housing, and financial security,” states the study. But the expanding ‘silver market’ provides incentives for start-ups, and large firms to carve out new markets, and expand niche ones. The opportunity lies in affordable and scalable business models.

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | MONDAY | MARCH 23, 2026

BUSINESS

10

Didi vs Dada, land vs industry

Does Bengal need welfare-linked growth, or double-engine one?

OUR TAKE

Jayanta Bhattacharya

Senior Journalist

Asansol (West Bengal): “In the runup to (assembly) elections, candidates promise that they will reopen a factory or other that was earlier folded up, with empty tracts of land lying unused. This time, I find that pitch has subdued. I guess that the politicians are either fed up or fear rebuke from the people for making false promises,” says 68-year-old Tej Naran Mishra, who once worked in a sprawling factory that made the popular Sen Raleigh bicycles, and is closed for decades. The factory lies vacant, and the adjoining area has residential quarters but most of the households may not have valid official documents.

However, if one hears the pitches made by the ruling Trinamool Congress, and opposing BJP, industry seems to be a crucial debate point in the ongoing election campaigns. Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee talks about growth wrapped in welfare logic and rhetoric. This comes naturally to a leader, whose rise coincided with the demonstrations against the Tata’s Nano (small car) project in Singur, and a bid by the Salim Group of Indonesia to build a chemical hub in Nandigram nearly 18 years ago. She stopped the industrial acquisitions of 997 acres in Singur, and 14,000 acres in Nandigram.

Riding on her pro-farmers’ land stance, and anti-industry protests, Mamta became the chief minister in 2011, and has ruled for 15 years. But as West Bengal goes for the state polls in April 2026, she focuses on welfare-driven growth, with claims that the state now attracts huge investments in steel, petrochemicals, and tourism. Among Trinamool Congress’ key promises are “10 Protigya (pledge)”, which include jobs for youth, housing, social schemes, and balancing welfare with selective industrial expansion. In 2025, leading business houses committed investments of Rs 1.33 lakh crore, and the state’s indus-

trial growth was 7.3 per cent, or higher than the national average.

The BJP, pulls no punches when it talks about industry. It frames the state of the state as one that suffers from an “industrial desertification,” initially under the Left Front regimes for 34 years, and later under the incumbent CM for 15 years. For almost 50 years, businesses deserted West Bengal, and left behind an industry-bereft desert. For the BJP, Singur is a symbol of missed economic opportunities, not political ascendancy. Hence, it promises industrial revival within a year. But it treads the ground carefully, and claims it will be done without farmland acquisitions. It offers the potential of “double-engine growth.”

Thus, there seems to be a two-way battle for industry at several levels. In the political arena, it is about putting welfare before industry, and putting industry before politics. In the minds of people like Tej Mishra, the debate is about new investments, which requires vast tracts of land, or revival of the closed-down factories, where land is available in abundance, either in their original shape or new avatars. While fresh acquisitions are emotive issues, as land is still crucial for the people, re-using land is a legal and political minefield. Both are complex issues, which can transform into unmanageable political hot potatoes.

Let us start this political-industrial journey, as we hit the campaign trail in West Bengal, with the closed-down Sen Raleigh factory, where tools, parts of machinery, and building materials have been stolen over the years. “My father worked with the company since the late 1950s. It was an ideal workplace, and offered several amenities to the workers. But when the founder, Sudhir Kumar Sen, died in 1959, the fortunes went

up and down,” remembers Mishra. The state-of-the-art factory, spread over 1.25 lakh sq ft, made 2,00,000 cycles a year, and could make “even aeroplanes,” had a brand that ruled the bicycle market.

In December 1971, there was a lockout to modernise the factory, and upgrade the machinery. It reopened in 1973, but was nationalised two years later. Production continued under the state-owned Cycle Corporation. Several litigations led to its closure in the 1990s. “In 1990, my father died and, as the eldest of the three brothers, I took up a job at the same factory. Soon, there were strong rumours of a closure. The exodus started with 600 employees, and another 250 quit. Finally, only 154 were left. We reached out to MLAs, and others, for compensation, which came to ₹4-5 lakh per person,” says Mishra.

Like Mishra, Asish Bagh, 61, was a second-generation employee at the Burnpur-based unit of Burn Standard Company Ltd (BSCL). Bagh joined in the 1980s, after his father’s death, just like Mishra. After going through ownership changes, and mergers, BSCL was nationalised in 1975, just like Sen Rayleigh. In 2010, the former’s engineering units at Howrah and Burnpur came under the control of the ministry of railways. “Burn Standard was associated with several iconic structures, and civic facilities, like the Howrah Bridge, Vivekananda Setu over Hooghly, and Dakshineswar Kali Temple,” says Bagh.

One of his current pastimes is to watch the wagons of a goods train, and see if they carry a plate above the wheels with the name, Burn Standard. “The outer shells of cannonballs in the second World War were made by us, as is the casing of the Brahmos,” he claims. Ironically, the takeover by the railways happened when Mamata Banerjee was the central railways minister. On April 4, 2018, the Centre closed down BSCL due to poor physical and financial performance for more than 10 years despite financial assistance and other support.

In yet another irony, the company made a profit, albeit small, of ₹98 crore in 2017-18. Bagh claims that it had assets worth ₹2,600 crore, parts of which were disposed arbitrarily, including prime locations in Kolkata. Bagh stays at the company’s residential quarters, with his wife, and a son. But there is no electricity and water. Promises made to restore them before the assembly elections are broken. Bagh’s family, and others like them are dubbed squatters. “Perhaps, the number of voters in the few polling booths in the area this place perhaps is not enough to convince the candidates to help us,” he laments.

Therein lies the conundrum. It may not be viable to use the land to revive the closed-down units. If new industries are set up, it may lead to a variation of Singur or Nandigram, although it is not farmers’ land, but is occupied by former employees, as in Bagh’s case, or by newcomers and migrants, as in Sen Rayleigh case. Both sets are voters, whose numbers may be small, but their eviction cries may be loud.

(The author has more than three decades of experience across print, TV, and digital media)

A Left-Handed Economist

Smelling musk of tr(i)ump(h)

Two theatrical trade titans test the tenets of their trillion tentacles

Indeed, some experts contend that not even a barrel out of the 140 million barrels will reach the US. Instead, Trump’s aim is to reduce the existing worries among the Americans, and shore up sentiments.

According to media reports, the “move is expected to benefit Asia, the top buyer of Middle Eastern oil.” In fact, the American energy secretary, Chris Wright, admitted it when he said that Iranian supplies could “get to Asia within three or four days, and hit the market after being refined over the coming month-and-a-half.” This is the third time that the treasury department temporarily waived sanctions in Iran in the past 2-3 weeks, ever since the war started on February 28. The idea is to bring down global crude oil prices nearer to \$100, or below it.

One can look at the moves in two other ways. Over the past two weeks, according to Lloyd’s List, 89 ships have crossed the Strait of Hormuz, which is apparently under siege by the Iranians, and a fifth of them were Iranian vessels that carried crude oil. In essence, despite the war, and despite the Strait’s closure, Iranian oil continued to flow. Hence, what America has done in three instances is to legitimise what was happening illegally through smuggling.

waiver is not a waiver, benefit, or help but an acknowledgement of failure.

Another way to look at the waiver moves is to see it from the perspective of the two of the largest global oil consumers, which are based in Asia, India, and China. In India’s case, it may be a matter of helping an ally-turned-

foe-turned-ally so that New Delhi inks the bilateral trade deal with Washington without protests. Some of the Iranian oil may reach India, which was among the major buyers before new American sanctions were imposed in 2018. This juxtaposes with the waiver to Russian oil, which was under the western sanctions.

Since the Russia-Ukraine war in 2022, Russia emerged as the largest oil supplier to India, thanks to hefty discounts, until the US put a lid on the supplies. But the temporary waiver has restarted them, and helped relieve the Indian energy crisis to an extent. However, Russian oil is no longer available at discounts, but at premiums to some consumers. One is not sure if the Indian refiners are paying above the market rates. The Russian-Iranian oil may be a carrot dangled by the Americans to push India to sign the trade deal without renegotiations.

How is Musk entangled with oil politics and geopolitics despite Tesla being an electric vehicle, although the satellite-launchers do use fossil fuels? His war with words, or rather way with words turned ugly due to a recent court order. A San Francisco federal court concluded that Musk misled investors prior to his Twitter takeover in 2022. Although Twitter, now X, faces competition from several other social media platforms, it is still popular in most nations. The jury found that many of Musk’s public utterances were intentional, and led investors down the wrong paths. Indeed, Musk may have lowered the acquisition cost.

Before the takeover, the potential owner made claims related to the problems with Twitter’s user metrics, and even hinted that he would back out of the \$44-billion deal. These helped him to pare down the stock price by \$3-8 per share, which enabled him to pay less to the shareholders. If the order is not challenged and changed, Musk may need to compensate investors in damages due to potential losses. Some lawyers feel that the verdict “sends a strong message. If you move the market with your words, you own the consequences.”

It may be a message to Trump too. If you talk about decimating Iran, time and again, and back the words with missiles and bombs, you will need to own the implications. You may need to ease sanctions.

The Pioneer

SINCE 1865

Vinaya: Strategies to reinforce a Responsible and Disciplined Society

विनय-मूलो दण्डः प्राणमृतां योग-क्षेम-आवहः ।।
कौटिलीयम् अर्थशास्त्रम् ०१.५.०२ ।।
The power of the state is rooted in self-discipline, which brings security and prosperity to the citizens. (Kautilya's Arthashastra: 1.05.02)

As India awoke to "life and freedom" after the British Raj ended and was replaced by Independent India, the framers of the Constitution bore great responsibility. This constitution, that shall define this country for centuries to come, was supposed to carve out a Democratic Republic from an erstwhile colony, and citizens with rights and respect from erstwhile subjects without any. The Constitution of the Republic of India was written in the shadows of two centuries of oppression, suppressed individual and collective identities, and erasure of cultural heritage. A carefully crafted, living document was being created to ensure no voice is left unheard, no stomach goes empty to sleep, no childhood passes without education, and no old age without familial warmth. This document, the longest constitution in the world, was not just drafted for a newly independent country. It was drafted for a dream: India, that is Bharat.

The exclusion of Fundamental Duties from the initial Constitution was not an omission, but a deliberate choice. "Subjects" who were forced to follow colonial orders and decrees with minimal rights to be identified as humans, let alone citizens, were at the base of this dream. Citizens of this new country were expected to innately love and respect what was hard earned; hence citizen duties were considered unsaid moral obligations. However, as a dynamic document, when the need arose, the Swaran Singh Committee suggested Fundamental Duties be a part of the Constitution. As part of the landmark 42nd Amendment Act in 1976, 10 Fundamental Duties were added as Part IV - A of the Indian Constitution. In 2002, one more duty was added by the 86th Amendment Act - finalising 11 Fundamental Duties for the citizens of India.

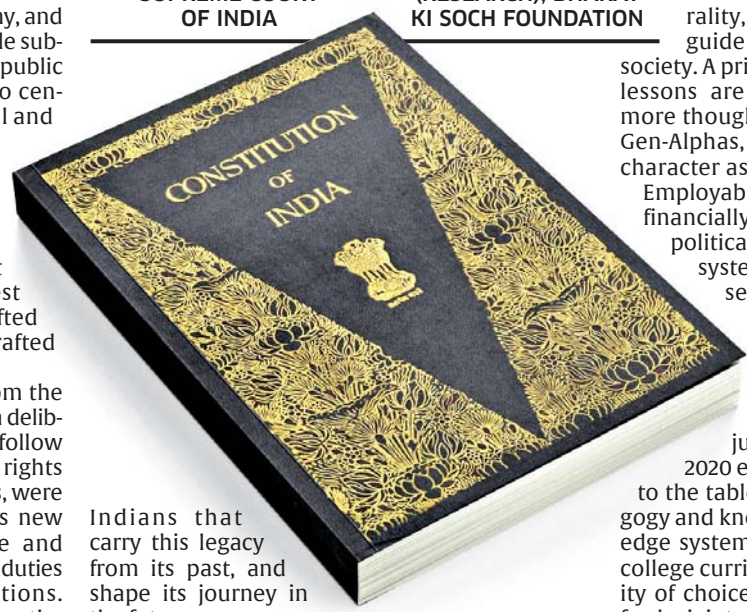
These 11 duties are the moral, social, and national obligations of every citizen of this country - thus "fundamental" in nature. The Supreme Court's Ranganath Mishra judgment 2003 held that Fundamental Duties should not only be enforced by legal sanctions but also by social sanctions. As we celebrate 77 years of being the Republic of India, we carry on our shoulders the heritage of 5000 years of civilisational grandeur despite centuries of challenging seasons that have threatened this heritage. This responsibility is to be shouldered at a national level - but more so at an individual level. The Republic of India is a cumulative whole of 1.4 billion



JUSTICE AK SIKRI
FORMER JUDGE,
SUPREME COURT
OF INDIA



TEJUSVI SHUKLA
ASSISTANT DIRECTOR
(RESEARCH), BHARAT
KI SOCH FOUNDATION



Indians that carry this legacy from its past, and shape its journey in the future.

While laying emphasis on self-discipline being at the root of any prosperous society, and an essential characteristic of any leader, Kautilya in his Arthashastra points out that this may not always be innate, but is also acquired (कृतकः स्वामाविकश्च विनयः ।। ०१.०५.०३ ।।). This leader-like stature is developed through vinaya or training and education. The 11th Fundamental Duty added in 2002 (as a citizen's responsibility enforcing the Right to Education Act, 2002) incidentally happens to have acknowledged this aspect. Kautilya suggests that this education shall involve four elements: anvikshiki, trayi, varta, and dandaniti. Each of these withold timeless relevance and adequate parallels with modern requirements.

Anvikshiki or logical reasoning is the primary element sowing the seeds of curiosity in every individual - the rationale to question, verify, judge, and act parting ways from a herd mentality. An act of selfless service or an act of self-reliance germinates through logical thinking, which may not be crum-

bled under the rote learning frameworks that make securing 90 per cent marks the end goal. This needs to be founded on robust knowledge or Trayi which encompasses training in fundamental secular and cultural knowledge such that manipulation of the self becomes difficult. With information overload in the 21st century, most societal damage emerges from unawareness and lack of purpose. Situating one's situational awareness within the ideals of the Constitution, cultural plurality, and civilisational grandeur helps guide one's curiosity and judgement as a society. A primer could be ensuring moral science lessons are re-inculcated in school syllabi in more thoughtful forms, to adapt to the needs of Gen-Alphas, for the development of strength in character as they grow up.

Employable training that shall secure the youth financially, and by consequence socially and politically is the second element of Kautilya's system of training. Varta or a training in secular sciences, forms the third crucial element of Kautilya's training schedule. The final element essentially holds the three and their relevance together - Dandaniti. Danda acts as the protector of order and faith in justice. The National Education Policy of 2020 envisioned similar reforms and brought to the table a fresh outlook of looking at pedagogy and knowledge systems. Indigenous knowledge systems were offered space in school and college curriculum, creative learning and flexibility of choices for students collectively breathed fresh air into the long colonised structures of tutoring, instead of guided learning. Six years old, the Policy is a fresh idea with a wide horizon yet to cover. Kautilya's ideas - ancient, but of contemporary relevance - thus offer critical guides to ensure that good vinaya leads to acquired self discipline in all citizens.

Having accomplished this, citizens become aware of the universe and themselves - developing a strength of character that makes them leaders, instead of blind followers. These leaders envision, craft, create, and drive themselves, while driving the country with them. These leaders are not affected by distractions. While taking responsibility and accountability, they drive the country forward. The spirit of the National Education Policy 2020 leads us in this direction, but a long walk lies waiting ahead - leading us to a Viksit Bharat. The dream of India, that is Bharat is a magnificent dream that has to be seen by 1.4 billion pairs of eyes, every day, with conviction and onus of the country's future on every shoulder that breathes its name.

Yaksha Prashna from the Mahabharata and Fundamental Duties

One day in the Kamyaka forest, as the Pandavas neared the end of their twelve-year exile the brothers became very exhausted due to heat. Yudhishtira sent Sahadeva to fetch water. At a serene lake, a celestial voice of the Yaksha cautioned Sahadeva, "This is my lake. Answer my questions before drinking." Sahadeva ignored it, and as he drank he fell lifeless. Nakula, Arjuna, and Bhima followed, each neglecting the voice and perishing by the water's edge.

Looking for his brothers, the grief-stricken Yudhishtira arrived near the lake. Heeding the Yaksha's command, he engaged in a profound dialogue of over 125 questions on ethics, dharma, and human nature through which he proved his mastery of righteous conduct. The Yaksha probed, "What is happiness?" Yudhishtira replied, "proper conduct." This echoes our fundamental duty 51A(e); promoting harmony and brotherhood transcending religious, linguistic, or regional divides.

"Who makes one enlightened, birth, character, or learning?" "Character alone," said Yudhishtira, aligning with fundamental duty 51 A(j): striving for excellence in individual and collective life. The Yaksha asked, "What is the invincible enemy and the incurable disease?" Yudhishtira replied, "anger and greed." These vices undermine our fundamental duty pertaining to abjuring violence and safeguarding public property.

To Yaksha's question "what is the highest duty?", Yudhishtira answered "Ahimsa or non-violence." Yaksha asked, "what is the loftiest thing?" to which

Dharmaraja replied "knowledge," tying with the fundamental duty 51A(k): parents' duty to educate children aged 6-14. ". To Yaksha's question regarding the friend of the dying?", Yudhishtira answered "charity."

Impressed by Dharmaraja's responses and humility, the Yaksha revealed



himself as Yama, God of Dharma and Yudhishtira's father.

He offered to revive only one brother. Yudhishtira chose Nakula, his step-brother from Madri so that both Kunti and Madri could have a living son for justice sake. This selflessness moved Yama to revive all. The episode underscores dharma's essence. Ethical conduct fosters societal harmony; character drives excellence, and non-violence ensures peace. These ancient truths mirror modern fundamental duties.

WISDOM WORD SEARCH

D H A R M A I F Q W R
A G A L I B A N D H I
N S A M V I D H A N A
D Y W S A B H A P Y K
A P A E G J K L M A N
R A J Y A L A I A R I
H A T A A D F G H T T
T Y H A O S E V A H I
O B P D E F G H I A L
L K A R T A V Y A Z D

WORDS TO FIND

Artha, Danda, Dharma, Kartavya, Niti, Nyaya, Rajya, Sabha, Samvidhana, Seva

ARTHA:

Purposeful economic activity and the creation of public wealth.

DANDA:

The "rod of punishment", the lawful application of authority.

DHARMA:

The ethical foundation that upholds the social and cosmic order.

KARTAVYA:

The inherent duty and responsibility of every citizen and ruler.

NITI:

The science of political ethics and strategic statecraft.

NYAYA:

The principle of justice and logical reasoning in governance.

RAJYA:

The state or kingdom functioning under the rule of law.

SABHA:

An assembly of wise counselors and representatives.

SAMVIDHANA:

The systemic framework that organizes and structures society.

SEVA:

The concept of leadership as a form of selfless service.

Marvels of India

KAILASHNATH TEMPLE, ELLORA

A Marvel of Indian Craftsmanship: The Kailashnath (Kailash) Temple at Ellora epitomises Bharat's architectural genius by uniting monumental scale, advanced engineering and refined sculptural artistry in a single rock-cut complex.

Monolithic Engineering Feat : Kailasa (Cave 16) is the world's largest monolithic rock-cut temple, carved top-down from a single basalt cliff of the Charanandri hills. Over 200,000 tonnes of rock were removed through a subtractive process, isolating and sculpting a freestanding, multi-storeyed temple. This irreversible method demanded exceptional planning and precision.

Architectural and Artistic Excellence: Rising about 32 metres and stretching nearly 78 metres, the temple rivals major structural shrines. Its walls, pillars and ceilings display dense narrative reliefs from the Ramayana, Mahabharata and Shaiva Puranic legends, along with life-sized animal sculptures.

Civilisational Significance: Conceived as a terrestrial Mount Kailash, the temple served as a Shaiva pilgrimage centre and a symbol of Rashtrakuta imperial power. Situated within the multi-religious Ellora complex, now a UNESCO World Heritage Site, it reflects Bharat's inclusive civilisational ethos.



Did you know?

Kautilya's Arthashastra (1.5.2) argues that a state's prosperity isn't just about laws, but the Vinaya (self-discipline) of its citizens. He believed that while some discipline is innate, true civic responsibility is acquired through education mirroring our 11th Fundamental Duty to provide education to children.

QUIZ

Governance (Fundamental Duties)

Questions	Option A	Option B	Option C	Option D
1 King Ashoka ordered tours by his officers every five years to - "inspect and preach Dhamma (moral and social code of conduct) in his dominions in addition to their regular duties, and to teach his people to obey parents, be liberal to friends, relatives, Brahmanas and Sramanas/Monks, and to abstain from killing animals". In which Girnar Rock Edict was this expressed?	2nd	3rd	4th	5th
2 Jain teachings advocate the 5 main vows to follow Dharma or duty. Which of them means "Don't steal from others"?	Virya	Aparigraha	PRAJNA	Asteya
3 "Do not destroy the forest where tigers roam and do not kill the tigers that live in forests." Which ancient text is this taken from?	Mahabharata	Susruta Samhita	Buddhacharita	Garuda Purana
4 In which civilization did the people show a very good civic sense amongst all other ancient civilizations?	Mesopotamian	Chinese	Indus Valley	Greek
5 Thirukkural by the poet Thiruvalluvar in the Tamil Sangam Age deals with three important concepts. Which of these mean Virtue/Righteous Living?	Aram	Inbam	Porul	Kurinji

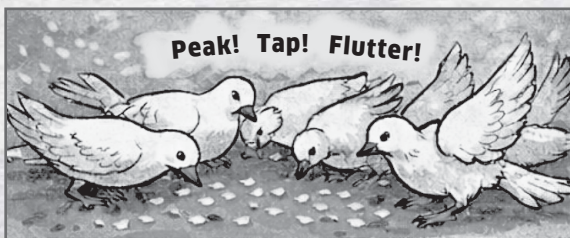
Answers: 1 - B, 2 - D, 3 - A, 4 - C, 5 - A

hitopadeśha

A Hunter, Trapped Doves and A Mouse



In the quiet forest, a hunter laid silent snare.



peak! Tap! Flutter!

The doves landed to eat the grains.



We are trapped!

But they were caught in the net.



Do not fear. Together, we are stronger than net.

Let us all rise as one! Let us fly to our friend, the mouse living near the stream to cut the net.



Together, they lifted the net and flew away.

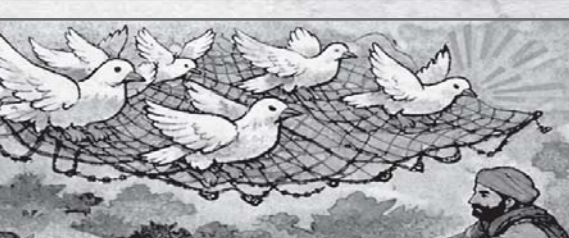


"A strong guide saves many lives!"

The mouse freed them all.



Friends in need never knock in vain!



The doves flew free. The hunter was left in despair.

MORAL OF THE STORY: Unity is strength

FROM THE WORLD

NEPAL

Restrictive orders re-imposed

Restrictive orders were re-imposed on Sunday in southern Nepal's Kaphilvastu district that had witnessed a clash between two communities turn violent. As the situation remained tense, the District Administration Office, Kaphilvastu re-imposed the restrictive orders in parts of Maharajgunj Municipality in the district. According to Janardan, Chief District Officer of Kaphilvastu, the step was taken as per the decision of the district security committee. The order restricts people from making a gathering, public meeting, rallies and demonstrations in different parts of the municipality. On Saturday morning, a group of Hindus observing Navaratri festival were reciting bhajans in Bargadwa area of Maharajgunj municipality when a group of Muslims celebrating Eid.

US

Gas prices offset refunds

The US economy was supposed to start the year with a bang, fuelled by an unusually large jump in tax refunds from President Donald Trump's tax cut legislation. Yet spiking gas prices are on track to eat up those refunds, leaving most Americans with little extra to spend. "Next spring is projected to be the largest tax refund season of all time," Trump said in a prime-time speech in December that was intended to address voters' concerns about the economy and stubbornly high prices. But that was before the Iran war, which began February 28. Oil and gas prices have soared since then, with the nationwide average price of gas reaching \$3.94 Sunday, up more than a dollar from just a month earlier. Gas prices are likely to remain elevated for some time, even if the war ends soon, because shipping and production have been disrupted and will take time to recover.

Hezbollah claims deadly strike on northern Israel



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Cairo

Hezbollah said it was behind a strike on Sunday that killed a man in the northern Israeli town of Misgav in what the Israeli military said "seemed to be" a rocket attack. Israeli medics said they found the man dead in his car and released a video showing two vehicles ablaze. Hezbollah, an ally of Iran, launched strikes on Israel soon after the US-Israeli attack on Iran started on February 28, saying it was in retaliation for the killing of Iran's Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei. Israel struck back, bombarding Lebanon and targeting Hezbollah in deadly airstrikes, expanding its presence in southern Lebanon and amassing more troops near the border. Lebanese authorities say Israel's strikes have killed more than 1,000 people and displaced more than 1 million. Israel's military said it was not able to intercept missiles that hit Dimona and Arad on Saturday, the largest cities near the Negev Desert nuclear centre.

Iran strikes near Israeli nuclear research centre

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Cairo

Iranian missiles struck two communities in southern Israel late Saturday, leaving buildings shattered and dozens injured in dual attacks not far from Israel's main nuclear research centre, while President Donald Trump warned the US will "obliterate" Iranian power plants if it doesn't fully open the Strait of Hormuz within 48 hours. The developments signalled the war was moving in a dangerous new direction at the start of its fourth week. Trump — who is facing increasing pressure at home to secure the strait as oil prices soar — issued the ultimatum in a social media post while he spent the weekend at his Florida home. Trump said he's giving Iran 48



Israeli Home Front Command officers inspecting an apartment building struck by an Iranian missile in Tel Aviv, Israel

hours to open the vital waterway or face a new round of attacks.

He said the US would destroy "various POWER PLANTS, STARTING WITH THE BIGGEST ONE FIRST!" The

Strait of Hormuz, which connects the Persian Gulf to the rest of the globe's oceans, is a critical pathway for the world's flow of oil. Attacks on commercial ships and threats

of further strikes have stopped nearly all tankers from carrying oil, gas and other goods through the passage. That's also led to cuts in output from some of the world's largest producers, because their crude has nowhere to go.

The Iranian strikes in Israel came after Tehran's main nuclear enrichment site at Natanz was hit earlier in the day.

Israel's military said it was not able to intercept missiles that hit the southern cities of Dimona and Arad, the largest near the centre in Israel's sparsely populated Negev desert. It was the first time Iranian missiles penetrated Israel's air defense systems in the area around the nuclear site.

"If the Israeli regime is unable to intercept missiles in the heavily protected Dimona area, it is, operationally, a sign of entering a new

phase of the battle," Iran's Parliament Speaker Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf said on X before word of the Arad strike spread.

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu said more emergency crews were being sent to the scene. "This is a very difficult evening," he said.

Rescue workers said the direct hit in Arad caused widespread damage across at least 10 apartment buildings, three of them badly damaged and in danger of collapsing. At least 64 people were taken to hospitals.

Dimona is about 20 km west of the nuclear research centre and Arad around 35 km north. Israel is believed to be the only West Asian nation with nuclear weapons, though its leaders refuse to confirm or deny their existence. The UN nuclear watchdog said on

X it had not received reports of damage to the Israeli centre or abnormal radiation levels.

"The war is not close to ending," Israel's army chief, Gen. Eyal Zamir, said earlier in the day.

Iran also targeted the joint UK-US Diego Garcia military base in the Indian Ocean about 4,000 km away, suggesting that Tehran has missiles that can go farther than previously acknowledged -- or that it had used its space programme for an improvised launch.

The US and Israel have offered shifting rationales for the war, from hoping to foment an uprising that topples Iran's leadership to eliminating its nuclear and missile programmes and its support for armed proxies. There have been no signs of an uprising, while internet restrictions limit information from Iran.

US-Israel fighting for entire world, says Netanyahu

HARINDER MISHRA
■ Jerusalem

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu on Sunday said the recent missile attacks on Diego Garcia shows that Iran has the capacity to reach deep into Europe and poses danger to the entire world. Netanyahu was visiting the southern Israeli city of Arad which faced Iranian missile strikes on Saturday evening when he also said his country and the US are fighting together on behalf of everyone. "If you want proof that Iran endangers the entire world, the last 48 hours have given it. In the last 48 hours, Iran targeted a civil-



Israel PM Netanyahu speaking to media during a visit in Arad, Israel

ian area. They're using that as a mass murder weapon. "Luckily, no one was killed, but that's due to luck, not their intention. Their intention is to murder civilians," Netanyahu said.

Pointing out that Iran fired an intercontinental ballistic missile on Diego Garcia,

Netanyahu said, "That's 4,000 kilometres. I've been warning all the time.

They now have the capacity to reach deep into Europe. They already have fired on European countries — Cyprus. They are putting everyone in their sights." For the past two decades,

Israel has been referring to the Iranian ballistic missile programme, arguing that such weapons with nuclear capabilities would pose a grave threat not only to itself but also to Europe.

Iran fired missiles at the UK-US air base on the island of Diego Garcia in the Indian Ocean on Saturday.

The Israeli prime minister also drew attention to the Iran's attack on Jerusalem right next to the holy sites of the three monotheistic faiths, the Western Wall, the Church of the Holy Sepulchre and the Al Aqsa Mosque and said, "By dint of a miracle, again, no one was hurt. "The three sites were nevertheless the targets," he said.

Iran's death toll now over 1,500: State broadcaster

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Cairo

More than 1,500 people have been killed in Iran during the war, the State broadcaster said, citing the health ministry. Residents said Iran's capital saw heavy airstrikes as they marked the end of the holy month of Ramadan.

Iran targeted a joint UK-US military base in the Indian Ocean, and Iran's main nuclear enrichment site was struck again, as the war in the West Asia entered its fourth week. Iran's attack on the Diego Garcia base -- 4,000 km away — suggested Tehran has missiles that can go



farther than previously acknowledged, or that it had used its space programme for an improvised launch.

The US and Israel have offered shifting rationales for the war, from hoping to foment an uprising that topples Iran's leadership to eliminating its nuclear and missile programmes and its support for armed proxies.

Sri Lanka hikes fuel prices by 25% amid West Asia conflict



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Colombo

The Sri Lankan Government on Sunday raised fuel prices by around 25 per cent, the second such increase in a week amid the West Asia conflict.

The step comes in the backdrop of the joint US-Israel strikes against Iran and the retaliation by the Islamic nation that has spread to the entire Gulf region. It has led to the closure of the Strait of Hormuz, a strategically important choke point for the world's energy supplies.

The island nation's Government hiked fuel prices effective midnight as the conflict, which has roiled global oil markets, entered its fourth week. The price of auto diesel rose 26.1 per cent from Sri Lankan rupees (LKR) 303 to LKR 382, super diesel 25.5 per cent from LKR 353 to LKR 443, petrol 92 octane 25.6 per cent from 317 to 398, petrol 95 octane 24.7 per cent from 365 to 455, and kerosene 30.8 per cent from 195 to 255.

The price hike, caused by the conflict, is the second in a week and the third since March 1. With the cost escalations, the fuel retail prices are set to return to the levels of the 2022 economic crisis, when Sri Lanka declared its first-ever sovereign default since gaining independence from Britain in 1948.

The unprecedented financial crisis led the then-president Gotabaya Rajapaksa to quit office in 2022 amid civil unrest. Due to the extensive fuel price hike, non-state bus operators in the island nation on Sunday warned that 90 per cent of their fleet may be off the road.

"This is the biggest rise of diesel ever, we will not be able to operate buses without an adequate fare revision. We need a minimum 15 per cent fare hike to stay afloat," Gamunu Wijeratne, the chair of the private bus owners' association, told reporters. The Lanka Private Bus Owners' Association announced a nationwide strike if the scheduled bus fare revision was not officially announced.

Japanese national detained in Iran last year has been released, says Motegi

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Tokyo

Japan's Foreign Minister Toshimitsu Motegi said Sunday that one of two Japanese nationals detained in Iran has been released and will be returning to Japan.

Motegi, speaking on a Fuji Television talk show, said the person had been detained since last year and was released on Wednesday.

He said another Japanese national who was arrested earlier this year is still in custody. Motegi said the release came after his repeated demands to Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi and that he is



Toshimitsu Motegi

"working to win an early release" of the other detainee while communicating with his family and other concerned parties.

The Committee to Protect Journalists has named the person detained in Iran in January as a journalist at Japan's public broadcaster NHK. The CPJ said the NHK

journalist was arrested January 20 by the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps and was transferred February 23 to Evin Prison, quoting unidentified sources citing fear of persecution.

Motegi did not identify either of the people detained and said the released Japanese national was detained in 2025.

The Foreign Ministry said earlier this month the detainees were safe and in good health, but only acknowledged that one was detained last year and the other one in January.

The ministry gave no further details such as whether the two cases were related.



Personnel posing for a group photograph with relief material aboard Indian Naval Ship Trikand after concluding a port call at Port Victoria, Seychelles

PTI

Jaishankar to address Indo-Russia trade conference

VINAY SHUKLA
■ Moscow

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar and his Russian counterpart Sergei Lavrov will on Monday virtually address a conference that will see experts from the two sides deliberate on navigating the choppy waters amid tension in the Gulf region.

The one-day conference organised by the Embassy of India in Moscow and the Russian International Affairs Council (RIAC) is especially significant considering the impact of the ongoing conflict in the Gulf region on the International North-South Transport Corridor (INSTC). Iran's Bandar Anzali, which faced damage due to



a missile strike by US-Israel on March 18, is a major port on the corridor that is a crucial link between Mumbai and St Petersburg, bypassing the Suez Canal, to boost trade between Asia and Europe.

Both India and Russia have pinned their hopes on the corridor for boosting bilateral trade to USD 100

billion by 2030, as was agreed to by Prime Minister Narendra Modi and President Vladimir Putin at their New Delhi summit in December. The conference 'Russia and India: Towards a New Agenda for Bilateral Relations' is a second attempt to chart the roadmap to enhance political, economic and cultural cooperation between the two strategic partners.

According to the schedule published by RIAC, the conference will be organised around three thematic blocks: political, economic, and cultural-humanitarian, with Government and public figures, representatives of the business and scientific communities attending the event. Jaishankar

and Lavrov will virtually address the conference at which two former ambassadors of India to Russia representing different think-tanks are expected to elaborate the Indian view on the rapidly changing situation in the world, RIAC said.

Apart from discussing the role of Russia and India in the changing global order in one of the plenaries, a session is likely to feature discussions on the role of the two countries' friends and partners, including Iran, Israel, US and other Gulf states, in the context of the ongoing war in West Asia.

Connectivity has been a bottleneck since the collapse of the Soviet Union and INSTC is expected to address this problem. (PTI)

Qatar confirms 6 killed in helicopter crash

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Cairo

Qatar said on Sunday six people have been confirmed killed in a Qatari helicopter crash in the Persian Gulf nation's territorial water.

The Interior Ministry said one person is still missing from the crash, which took place the day before.

The Defence Ministry blamed "technical malfunction" for the helicopter crash. The Interior Ministry's statement didn't clarify the nationality of the dead or say if they were civilian or military.

Meanwhile Iran's attack this week on Qatar's natural gas export facility threatens



to disrupt not just world energy markets but also global technology supply chains because the helium it produces is crucial for a range of advanced industries.

Best known as the gas that makes party balloons float, helium is also a key input in chipmaking, space rockets and medical imaging.

eign state," the then diplomat said in the telegram. The resolution moved by Landsman urges the House of Representatives to condemn the atrocities committed by the Armed Forces of Pakistan against the people of Bangladesh on March 25, 1971.

The resolution "recognizes that while the Pakistani Army and its Islamist allies indiscriminately mass-murdered ethnic Bengalis regardless of their religion and gender, killed their political leaders, intellectuals, professionals, and students, and forced tens of thousands of women to serve as their

sex slaves." "They specifically targeted the religious minority Hindus for extermination through mass slaughtering, gangrape, conversion, and forcible expulsion," it added.

Noting that entire ethnic groups or religious communities are not responsible for the crimes committed by their members, the resolution calls on the President of the United States to recognise the atrocities committed against ethnic Bengali Hindus by the Armed Forces of Pakistan during 1971 and their allies in the Jamaat-e-Islami as crimes against humanity, war crimes, and genocide. (PTI)

Declare Pakistan atrocities against Bengali Hindus in 1971 as genocide: US lawmaker

SAGAR KULKARNI
■ Washington

US Congressman Greg Landsman has introduced a resolution in the US House of Representatives seeking to recognise the atrocities committed by the Pakistani Army and its allies, Jamaat-e-Islami, against Bengali Hindus on March 25, 1971, as "war crimes and genocide".

Landsman, a Democrat Congressman from Ohio, moved the resolution in the US House of Representatives on Friday, and it has been referred to the Committee on Foreign Affairs. The resolution states that on the night of March



US Congressman Greg Landsman

25, 1971, the Government of Pakistan imprisoned Sheikh Mujibur Rahman, and its military units, in conjunction with radical Islamist groups inspired by the ideology of Jamaat-e-Islami, began a general crackdown throughout East Pakistan code-named "Operation Searchlight" that involved widespread massacres of civilians.

It said that on March 28, 1971, United States Consul General in Dacca, Archer Blood, sent a telegram to Washington titled "Selective Genocide", in which he wrote, "Moreover, with support of Pak military, non-Bengali Muslims are sys-

tematically attacking poor people's quarters and murdering Bengalis and Hindus".

Landsman noted that on April 6, 1971, in what became known as the "Blood Telegram", Consul General Blood sent an objection to the official United States Government silence on the conflict, signed by 20 members of the Consulate General Dacca. "But we have chosen not to intervene, even morally, on the grounds that the Awami conflict, in which unfortunately the overworked term genocide is applicable, is purely an internal matter of a sover-

Sudan hospital strike kills 64: WHO

FAY ABUELGASIM
■ Cairo

At least 64 people were killed, including at least 13 children, in a strike on a hospital in Sudan's western Darfur region last week, the World Health Organisation (WHO) said.

The strike on the Al Daein Teaching Hospital in East Darfur on Friday also injured at least 89 people and rendered the hospital non-functional, Tedros Ghebreyesus, the head of the WHO, said on X.

Sudan slid into chaos in April 2023 when a power struggle between the military and the rival paramilitary Rapid Support Forces exploded into war throughout the country. The RSF



has blamed the military for the strike on the hospital. The army has denied the

attack, but two military officials said the strike was targeting a nearby police

station. They spoke on the condition of anonymity as they were not allowed to discuss the matter openly.

The devastating war has killed more than 40,000 people, according to UN figures, but aid groups say that is an undercount and the true number could be many times higher.

The WHO has said that over 2,000 people have been killed in attacks on medical facilities since the start of the war.

"Enough blood has been spilled. Enough suffering has been inflicted. The time has come to de-escalate the conflict in Sudan," said Ghebreyesus. (AP)

Israeli settlers smash cars on Palestinians in West Bank



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Ramallah

Israeli settlers rampaged through multiple Palestinian villages overnight on Saturday and into Sunday, smashing cars, setting fires and wounding several men in the latest flare-up of violence in the occupied West Bank.

The official Palestinian news agency WAFA reported attacks in at least six communities on Sunday.

The Palestinian Red Crescent Society said at least three Palestinians in the village of Jalud suffered head wounds from beatings and were hospitalised after confronting settlers, who were also reported injured. The violence came as Israel's Government presses ahead with new settlements in the occupied West Bank. Attacks by settlers have intensified alongside a broader surge in violence since the Iran war started.

Israel's military said it responded to Israeli civilians carrying out "arson against structures and property, as well as engaging in disturbances in the area," but did not report any arrests or indicate whether investigations were opened.

Ex-FBI Director Robert Mueller dies at 81



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Washington

Robert S. Mueller III, the FBI director who transformed the nation's premier law enforcement agency into a terrorism-fighting force after the September 11, 2001, attacks and who later became special counsel in charge of investigating ties between Russia and Donald Trump's presidential campaign, has died. He was 81.

"With deep sadness, we are sharing the news that Bob passed away" on Friday night, his family said in a statement Saturday. "His family asks that their privacy be respected."

At the FBI, Mueller set about almost immediately overhauling the bureau's mission to meet the law enforcement needs of the

21st century, beginning his 12-year tenure just one week before the Sep 11 attacks and serving across presidents of both political parties. He was nominated by Republican President George W Bush.

The cataclysmic event instantaneously switched the bureau's top priority from solving domestic crime to preventing terrorism, a shift that imposed an almost impossibly difficult standard on Mueller and the rest of the federal Government: preventing 99 out of 100 terrorist plots wasn't good enough.

Later, he was special counsel in the Justice Department's investigation into whether the Trump campaign illegally coordinated with Russia to sway the outcome of the 2016 presidential race.

Italy's justice referendum becomes test for Meloni

GIADA ZAMPANO AND PAOLO SANTALUCIA
■ Rome

Italy's conservative Premier Giorgia Meloni faces a pivotal political test in a two-day referendum on judicial reform that starts Sunday, a vote that has transformed into a broader judgment on her leadership at home and abroad.

Originally presented as a technical overhaul of the justice system, the reform has sharpened political divisions and unified the centre-left opposition, turning the referendum into a symbolic showdown on Meloni's strength one year ahead of national elections.

Recent polls show the race remains too close to call, with the "No" camp gaining late momentum in a polarised climate where turnout may prove decisive.

Lorenzo Pregliasco, political analyst and polling expert at YouTrend, said a rejection of the reform would carry significant political weight.

"A possible 'No' victory would send a political signal, weakening Meloni's aura of invincibility, while pushing the centre-left opposition to say that there is already an alternative in the country," he told *The Associated Press*.

Meloni raises the stakes. Meloni initially avoided tying her image too closely to the referendum, wary of the danger that a defeat could weaken her domestically and abroad. She currently presides over Italy's most stable Government in years, after gaining credibility among her



Giorgia Meloni

European allies as a charismatic leader. A referendum win would further strengthen her tenure at home, alongside her international standing. That's why, as the vote neared and polls tightened, the Italian premier shifted strategy and fully embraced the "Yes" campaign.

Meloni has sharpened her rhetoric, accusing parts of the judiciary of hindering Government work on migration and security, and warning that failure to pass the reform would strengthen unaccountable judicial "factions" and endanger citizens' safety. "If the reform doesn't pass this time, we will probably not have another chance," she said at a campaign event last week.

"We will find ourselves with even more powerful factions, even more negligent judges, even more surreal sentences, immigrants, rapists, pedophiles, drug dealers being freed and putting your security at risk." Her stark warnings have drawn fierce criticism from magistrates and the centre-left, who argue that the reforms would erode judicial independence and undermine constitutional guarantees. (AP)

French voters head to polls in second round of local election

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Paris

French voters are returning to the polls on Sunday for the second and final round of municipal elections in over 1,500 communes.

The vote is a test of the balance of power on France's local political map before the 2027 presidential race begins to take shape.

It is also a measure of whether the far right can convert national momentum into control of major cities, where it has often struggled to break through.

The most closely watched contests are concentrated in major cities after a first round that left France's traditional left and right competitive, the



far right strongly placed in several urban races, and President Emmanuel Macron's Renaissance movement keeping a low profile in many of the most closely watched races.

After days of mergers, withdrawals and tactical deals between lists, three-way races remain common in the runoff. Paris is one of

the biggest prizes. Emmanuel Gregoire, heading a united left and green list, finished first in the opening round with 37.98 per cent of the vote, ahead of conservative Rachida Dati on 25.46 per cent, while La France Insoumise candidate Sophia Chikirou stayed in the race, setting up a volatile three-way contest.

Cuba's power grid collapses leaving it without electricity 3rd time this month

ANDREA RODRIGUEZ
■ Havana

Cuba's power grid collapsed leaving the country without electricity for a third time in March as the communist Government battles with a decaying infrastructure and a US-imposed oil blockade.

The Cuban Electric Union, which reports to the Ministry of Energy and Mines, announced a total blackout across the island without initially giving a cause for the outage.

The union later said the blackout was caused by an unexpected failure of a generating unit at the Nuevitas thermoelectric plant in Camaguey province. "From that moment, a cascading effect occurred in the machines



that were online," said a report from the Ministry of Energy and Mines, which activated "micro-islands" of generating units to provide power to vital centres, hospitals and water systems.

Authorities said they were working to restore power. Power outages, whether nationwide or regional, have become relatively common in the last two years due to breakdowns in the aging infrastructure. The breakdowns are compounded by daily blackouts of up to 12 hours caused by fuel shortages, which also destabilise the system. The last nationwide blackout occurred on Monday.

Saturday's outage was the second in the past week and the third in March.

The blackouts have a significant impact on the population, whose lives are disrupted by reduced work hours, lack of electricity for cooking and food spoilage when refrigerators stop working, among many other consequences. In some cases, hospitals have cancelled surgeries. (AP)

Slovenia's governing liberals face right-wing populists in tight parliamentary election

ALI ZERDIN
■ Ljubljana (Slovenia)

Voters in Slovenia headed to the polls in a highly contested parliamentary election that pits the governing liberals against right-wing populists in a vote that will decide whether the small European Union nation stays on its liberal course or sways toward the right.

The race is expected to be tight and follows a campaign rocked by allegations of foreign interference that stunned the traditionally moderate EU country.

The vote comes down to two main players: Prime Minister Robert Golob's Freedom Movement and



the right-wing Slovenian Democratic Party, or SDS, led by three-time premier Janez Jansa, a populist-style politician and an admirer of US President Donald Trump.

Who wins will resonate wider in the 27-member EU bloc. Golob's Government has

been a strong liberal voice in the bloc while a victory of Jansa - also a close ally of nationalist Hungarian Prime Minister Viktor Orban - would strengthen Europe's surging populist groups. "Although Slovenia is a small Balkan country, the elections taking

place there could be seen as another sign of the rise of illiberal tendencies in Europe," Helen Levy, a researcher at the Robert Schuman Foundation, wrote in an analysis last month. Slovenian sociologist Samo Uhan told *The Associated Press* that "the biggest differences between the Government and the opposition are reflected in their understanding of global developments."

Slovenia's top two parties have been running neck and neck in recent polls and analysts predict that no party would have a clear majority in the 90-member parliament, which would turn smaller parties into kingmakers. (AP)

Trump set to feature on gold coin to celebrate 250 years of US independence

SAGAR KULKARNI
■ Washington

US President Donald Trump is all set to feature on a gold coin to commemorate the nation's 250th anniversary, amid questions over the legality of the move.

The 24-karat gold coin, portraying Trump leaning on the Resolute desk with clenched fists, will be only the second time a living president has featured on a coin.

Earlier, Calvin Coolidge, the 30th US President had featured on a commemorative coin alongside George Washington that were minted in 1926 to celebrate 150 years of the US Independence.

The US Commission on Fine Arts, at its meeting on March 19, approved the design of the commemorative gold coin, which will be minted once the final dimensions are decided. "As we approach our 250th birthday, we are thrilled to prepare coins that represent the enduring spirit of our country and



democracy, and there is no profile more emblematic for the front of such coins than that of our serving President, Donald J Trump," US Treasurer Brandon Beach said in a statement to FOX Business.

US Federal law States that no living president can appear on US currency.

However, Beach said the proposed commemorative coin would be separate from circulating currency and the Treasury Secretary has sole discretion over the final design selection and authorising its minting. (PTI)

ICE officers soon to help with airport security, says Trump

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Washington

President Donald Trump said he will order federal immigration officers to take a role in airport security starting on Monday unless Democrats agree on a bill to fund the Department of Homeland Security. In a pair of social media posts, Trump first



threatened and then said he had made plans to put officers from US Immigration and Customs Enforcement in airports if the congressional standoff continues. He made the announcement as a partial shutdown contributes to long lines to pass through screening at some of the nation's largest airports.

The Republican president suggested ICE agents would bring the administration's immigration crackdown into the nation's airports, promising to arrest "all illegal immigrants."

"I look forward to moving ICE in on Monday, and have already told them to, 'GET READY.' NO MORE WAITING, NO MORE GAMES!" Trump wrote while spending the weekend in Florida. (AP)

How Ukraine's front line became a laboratory for drone innovation

HANNA ARHIROVA
■ Kharkiv

The night air in eastern Ukraine is crisp, and a myriad of stars scatter above a small crew of soldiers watching for Iranian-designed Shahed drones that Russia launches in waves.

Such teams are deployed across the country as part of a constantly evolving effort to counter the low-cost loitering munitions that have become a deadly weapon of modern warfare, from Ukraine to the West Asia.

While waiting, the crew from the 127th Brigade tests and fine-tunes their self-made interceptor drones, searching for flaws that could undermine performance once the buzzing threat appears.

When Shahed drones first appeared in autumn 2022, Ukraine had few ways to stop them. Today, drone crews intercept them in flight with continually adapting technology.

In recent years, Ukraine's domestic drone interceptor market has burgeoned, producing some key players who tout their products at international arms shows. But it's on the front line where small teams have become laboratories of rapid military innovation — grassroots technology born of battlefield necessity that now draw international interest.

President Volodymyr Zelenskyy says US allies in the west Asia have approached Ukraine for help in defending against Iranian drones, the same type that Russia has fired



by the tens of thousands in the 4-year-old war.

Iran has also used the same drones in retaliation for joint US-Israeli strikes, at times overwhelming far more sophisticated Western-made air defenses and

highlighting the need for cheaper and more flexible countermeasures. "It's not like we sat down one day and decided to fight with drones," said a pilot with Ukraine's 127th Brigade, sitting at his monitor after completing a preflight check.

"We did it because we had nothing else." How the drone war began. Moments earlier, the pilot carefully landed his interceptor drone to avoid damaging it. He spoke on condition of anonymity because military rules did not allow him to be quoted by name.

Though designed to be disposable, limited resources mean Ukrainian crews try to preserve every tool they have, often reusing even single-use drones to study their weaknesses and improve them.

"Just imagine - a Patriot missile costs about \$2 million, and here you have a small aircraft worth about \$2,200," the pilot said. "And if it doesn't hit the target, I can land it, fix it a bit and send it back into the air. The difference is huge. And

the effect? Not any worse." Ukraine's 127th Brigade is building an air defense unit centered on interceptor drone crews - a model increasingly adopted across the military. Leading the brigade's effort is a 27-year-old captain, who previously served in another formation where he had already helped organize a similar system.

He also spoke on condition of anonymity because military rules did not allow him to be quoted by name.

He clearly remembers the moment about two years ago when everything changed. He said he was assigned to lead a group of soldiers ordered to intercept Russian reconnaissance drones using shoulder-fired air-defense missiles. (AP)



PROSPECT

Bihar DISCOMs shine in national power rankings



In a significant boost to Bihar’s infrastructure credentials, the State’s power distribution sector has recorded a stellar performance in the latest national assessments released by the Union Ministry of Power and REC Limited. North Bihar Power Distribution Company Limited (NBPDC) has secured a prestigious ‘A’ rating in the Consumer Service Rating of DISCOMs (CSR), emerging among the top five state-owned utilities in the country.

The Distribution Utilities Ranking (DUR) Report further highlighted the State’s progress, placing NBPDC in the top five and South Bihar Power Distribution Company Limited (SBPDCL) at the 13th spot nationally. These rankings reflect a robust structural transformation, driven by improved billing efficiency, reduced AT&C losses, and the aggressive roll-out of smart prepaid meters.

Energy Minister Bijendra Prasad Yadav hailed the achievement, stating it underscores the Government’s commitment to providing reliable and affordable power. Manoj Kumar Singh, Energy Secretary and CMD of BSPHCL, attributed the success to technology-driven reforms and enhanced grievance redressal mechanisms.

The assessment evaluated 66 utilities on parameters including operational reliability and financial sustainability. With a continued focus on digitalisation, Bihar’s DISCOMs are now positioned as national benchmarks in consumer-centric service delivery.

Yamaha Music India appoints AR Rahman as brand ambassador



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Yamaha Music India has appointed music legendary AR Rahman as its Brand Ambassador. This landmark collaboration underscores the company’s commitment to advancing India’s music ecosystem and nurturing the next generation of musical talent.

According to a press release, a global icon who has redefined Indian music on the world stage, Rahman’s journey reflects the immense potential of Indian artistry.

Yamamoto Taketoshi, Managing Director, Yamaha Music India, said Music lies at the heart of Yamaha’s philosophy. “India’s rich musical heritage deserves global recognition. Through our

‘Made in India’ initiative and our collaboration with A.R. Rahman, we aim to inspire the next generation of musicians and expand structured music education across India,” he said.

Speaking on the association Rahman said Yamaha has always represented precision and reliability. “I am proud to associate with a brand whose legacy is rooted in music excellence and whose ‘Made in India’ focus is making quality instruments more accessible.

This initiative is already benefiting the young talents being nurtured at my own KM Music Conservatory and in The Sunshine Orchestra. If we continue to mentor young artists and strengthen music education, Indian musicians can lead on the global stage,” he added.

Government may consider OFS option for raising public float in IDBI Bank

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Government may consider selling a stake in IDBI Bank through the Offer-for-Sale (OFS) route to increase public shareholding, after the unsuccessful attempt to divest stake in the LIC-controlled lender, sources said.

Currently, the public float in IDBI Bank is only 5.29 per cent, limiting the scope of fair valuation.

The remaining shares are with insurance behemoth Life Insurance Corporation of India (LIC), with a controlling stake at 49.24 per cent, while the Government of India (GoI) holding stood at 45.48 per cent.

Earlier this month, the proposed sale of a 60.72 per cent majority stake, held jointly by the Government and the LIC, was scrapped after financial bids from two potential buyers reportedly fell short of the reserve price.

Low free float restricts the scope for fair market valuation, and expanding this by 10 per cent or 15 per cent would make price discovery more reliable, sources said.

LPG cargo ship from US arrives at Mangaluru Port



The Singapore-flagged cargo ship Pyxis Pioneer arrives at New Mangalore Port carrying LPG from Port of Nederland, Texas in Mangaluru on Sunday PTI

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mangaluru

An LPG cargo ship from the US arrived at the New Mangalore Port on Sunday, amid the supply constraints due to the ongoing war in the West Asia. The vessel “Pyxis Pioneer”, which left Port of Nederland in Texas on

February 14, brought 16,714 metric tonnes of Liquefied Petroleum Gas (LPG) for discharge to Aegis Logistics, officials said.

The vessel follows the Russian “Aqua Titan” ship in reaching the port within the span of a day. The development is considered significant as Mangaluru is home to

India’s largest underground LPG storage facility, which became operational in September 2025. The storage facility, located 225 metres below sea level, has a capacity of 80,000 metric tonnes.

In an earlier development, a Russian crude oil tanker named “Aqua Titan”, originally headed to China, was

diverted to India a few days ago. The ship arrived off the Mangaluru coast on Saturday evening carrying 7.7 lakh barrels of crude oil. The crude is reportedly being unloaded via an offshore pipeline connected to a jetty 12 nautical miles from the shore to the Mangalore Refinery and Petrochemicals Ltd (MRPL).

Ethanol industry ready to supply more than 20% blending, can cut crude import bill: AIDA

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

With West Asia in turmoil and crude oil prices rising, the All India Distillers’ Association (AIDA) has offered to supply ethanol blends exceeding 20 per cent with petrol, saying the move could proportionally reduce India’s dependence on imported crude oil.

In a letter to Union Minister for Road Transport and Highways Nitin Gadkari, AIDA Deputy Director General Bharati Balaji said the ethanol industry was prepared to go beyond the E20 target already achieved by the country.

“Now with the Middle East entangled in a war and oil prices having started increasing, we as an ethanol indus-



try are ready to offer ethanol more than 20 per cent which will reduce proportionally the import of crude,” she said in the letter.

She said such a step will mitigate supply disruptions and adverse economic impact on the country.

India achieved its E20 ethanol blending target —

mixing 20 per cent ethanol with petrol — ahead of schedule in 2025, a goal set under Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s administration to cut fuel import bills and reduce emissions. The association has demanded that the Government raise the ethanol blending mandate gradually from 20 to 30 per

cent. Among other demands, AIDA has called for introduction of flex-fuel vehicles capable of running on 100 per cent ethanol on the lines of Brazil, promotion of ethanol-based cook stoves for domestic and commercial use, and exploration of ethanol blending in diesel to contain costs.

The industry body said ethanol-based cooking solutions could serve as a clean energy option, particularly in semi-urban and rural areas, aligning with national priorities on clean energy access and reduced indoor air pollution. India’s ethanol sector now has a cumulative production capacity of around 2,000 crore litres, with more than 380 dedicated distilleries operational and a further 33 in the pipeline.

Tata Capital receives ₹413 crore tax demand; to challenge reassessment order

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Non-banking finance company Tata Capital has received a reassessment order from tax authorities, raising a demand of ₹413.18 crore for the financial year 2017-18, the firm said.

The order, issued by the Deputy Commissioner of Income Tax, Mumbai, under the Income-tax Act and uploaded on March 20, 2026, pertains to Tata Capital Financial Services Ltd (TCFSL), which has since been merged with Tata Capital with



effect from April 1, 2023.

The demand includes interest of ₹202.72 crore and primarily arises due to alleged short credit of taxes paid and certain disal-

lowances, Tata Capital said in a stock exchange filing on Saturday.

However, the company said the demand is based on apparent errors in the com-

putation. It stated that the assessing officer incorrectly allowed a tax credit for Tata Capital instead of TCFSL, leading to a shortfall in credit and consequential interest levy. Tata Capital said the entire demand, comprising ₹209.52 crore of tax and ₹202.72 crore of interest, is not sustainable.

The company said, “It will take necessary steps to file rectification application/appeal. The company expects a favourable outcome in respect to the above matter.”

Also, the company said it has filed or is in the process

of filing appeals against disallowances with a tax impact of ₹26.31 crore. It expressed confidence in receiving relief, citing strong legal grounds and judicial precedents.

“Based on our current assessment, we expect favourable orders on these disallowances since there are strong grounds and judicial precedent in respect of the disallowances made in the order,” Tata Capital said.

The company added that it does not expect any material impact on its financials, operations, or business due to the order.

Coal imports likely to remain subdued in near term



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The country’s coal imports dropped 4.2 per cent to 213.10 million tonnes (MT) in the April-January period of the current fiscal year and with seaborne prices showing an uptick, imports are likely to remain subdued in the near term.

The decline underscores the country’s push towards self-reliance in coal production amid surging domestic output, even as global thermal coal prices firm up due to supply constraints and geopolitical tensions.

According to data compiled by mjunction services Ltd, a B2B e-commerce platform and joint venture of SAIL and Tata Steel, during April-January period of the current financial year, non-coking coal import was at 127.80 MT, lower than 141.18 MT imported during the same period last fiscal year.

Coking coal import was at 50.39 MT during April-January 2025-26, up from 45.83 MT in the year-ago period.

The country’s import in January was down 22.1 per cent to 16.64 MT, over 21.37 MT imported in January last fiscal year. Of the total import in January, non-coking coal import stood at 9.45 MT, lower than 12.33 MT imported in January last financial year. Coking coal import was at 4.23 MT, compared to 5.23 MT imported in January last financial year.

“There was a significant drop in thermal coal import (on y-o-y basis), amid high inventory available in the domestic market.

West Asia conflict: L&T hopes Govt will continue capex, opt for wider fiscal deficit

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Amid concerns over a surge in import bill because of commodity price hardening in the wake of the Middle East conflict, Larsen & Toubro is hoping that the Government continues with its capital expenditure even if it means a widening of fiscal deficit.

The engineering, procurement and construction major feels the Government should borrow more if needed to continue with capital expenditure, a senior official has said.

“The import bill will go up because of oil and gas prices. The Government will have to balance it. They will maybe temporarily raise the deficit, may be they will borrow more,” its Deputy Managing Director Subramanian Sarma told reporters over the weekend.

“Overall, if you look at it, our fiscal situation is pretty good... we have some headroom so that we don’t compromise on the capital for the infrastructure,” Sarma



added. He also noted India has been able to curtail the fiscal deficit after the impact of the Covid pandemic.

Spends on infrastructure are necessary to achieve Viksit Bharat 2047 goals, Sarma said.

Even the US, which, alongside Israel, started the conflict by attacking Iran, leading to subsequent retaliations and the hardening of commodity prices, is aware of the challenges and implementing strategies to not let oil prices skyrocket.

The ongoing crisis will lead to rethink on the dependence on oil and gas for our energy needs, and bring to the fore troubles caused by the Strait of Hormuz, Sarma said, adding that this may lead to faster adoption of

non-fossil energy sources like green hydrogen and renewable energy.

L&T expects thermal power to continue being the mainstay of the energy needs, and is trying to capitalise on other opportunities that will be presented through the transition to newer energy sources, Sarma said.

Its green hydrogen production is doing well and the company has upped the capacity to 4 MW from the earlier 0.5 MW, Sarma said, adding that at present, its manufacturing capacity is 250 MW per annum. About 95 MW of capacity will be used at an upcoming facility in Panipat being built for Indian Oil Corporation in Panipat, he said.

▼ BRIEFLY

PSG retakes Ligue 1 lead after defeating Nice



Dro Fernandez scored his first goal for Paris Saint-Germain (PSG) as it won at struggling Nice 4-0 and reclaimed top spot in Ligue 1. The 18-year-old midfielder joined from Barcelona in January and grabbed his side's third goal after being neatly set up by Ousmane Dembele in the 81st minute. PSG moved one point above Lens, which crushed Angers 5-1 on Friday. Defending champion PSG has played one game less, and the sides meet on April 11 in Lens in what could be a title decider. Nice competed evenly until a contentious handball decision gave PSG a penalty late in the first half. Desire Doue's shot was off target and lightly brushed the arm of Nice midfielder Morgan Sanson, who was turning his back and unsighted. The referee awarded a penalty following a video review, and left back Nuno Mendes scored. Mendes then set up Doue in the 49th with a cross and, after Nice midfielder Youssef Ndayishimiye was sent off on the hour, PSG added late goals from Fernandez and right back Warren Zaire-Emery.

Bundesliga: Kane scores again as Bayern crush Union Berlin



Harry Kane scored again, and Bayern Munich stepped closer toward its 13th Bundesliga title in 14 years after beating Union Berlin 4-0. Kane scored after the break for his 31st league goal. He has seven more rounds to try and match Robert Lewandowski's season record of 41. Serge Gnabry scored twice, and Michael Olise also grabbed a goal for Bayern, taking the team's tally after 27 rounds to 97, on course to smash the season record of 101 goals set by Bayern in 1971-72. "It'll fall," Bayern sports director Christoph Freund said of the record. Midfielder Aleksandar Pavlovic dropped out at short notice with hip problems, and the Bavarian powerhouse was without three suspended players – Nicolas Jackson, Luis Diaz, and Jonathan Tah – while Jamal Musiala, Alphonso Davies and regular goalkeeper Manuel Neuer were injured. Bayern coach Vincent Kompany had several youngsters among the substitutes. Bayern stayed nine points clear of Borussia Dortmund in the Bundesliga. "We're right where we have to be and want to be," Kompany said of the team's form before its Champions League date with Real Madrid next month. Rami Bensebaini scored two penalties as Dortmund came from behind to beat Hamburger SV 3-2 at home to consolidate second. Philip Otele and Albert Sambi Lokonga scored in the first half for Hamburg, while Felix Nmecha, whose mistake led to the second goal, also missed a penalty for Dortmund before the break.

Duplantis clinches 4th straight world indoor pole vault title

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Torun (Poland)

Armand Duplantis won another pole vault world title after he was pushed all the way by Greece's Emmanouil Karalis. Duplantis won his fourth consecutive world indoor championships with a tournament record vault of 6.25 metres, a 10-centimetre improvement on his winning height a year ago in Nanjing. The pair left behind the field at 6.05. Duplantis cleared his first attempts at 6.10, 6.15 and then 6.25, when he wobbled the bar. Karalis passed at 6.10 and 6.15 and missed his attempts at 6.25, finishing runner-up for a second straight year.



Duplantis put away his pole, foregoing attempts at 6.32 to break his world record of 6.31 that he set last week at the Swedish meeting named after him, the Mondo Classic. "I am proud to have come through for the win. Today, it was about the battle. It

Indian team improved significantly: Joakim

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The India U20 women's team has made "significant improvement" since securing qualification, head coach Joakim Alexandersson said, expressing confidence that the side can compete strongly against Asia's elite in the upcoming AFC U20 Women's Asian Cup in Thailand. The Young Tigresses, who have arrived in Bangkok well in advance of the tournament, will open their Group C campaign against Japan on April 2, followed by matches against Australia (April 5) and Chinese Taipei (April 8). The top two teams from

each group, along with the two best third-placed sides, will progress to the quarter-finals, with the last-four stage offering qualification for the FIFA U20 Women's World Cup in Poland later this year. Reflecting on the team's journey since the qualifiers in August, Alexandersson said the side has evolved across departments. "There has been significant improvement. I've seen better ball movement, quicker passing, and more clarity in the final third. Even defensively, we are more organised, and the communication, especially from the goalkeepers, has improved. Every area we identified for improvement has pro-



gressed," he said. Placed in a challenging group, Alexandersson acknowledged the quality of opponents but stressed the impor-

tance of belief. "It's definitely a tough group. Japan is one of the best teams in the world at this level, and Australia are very strong and physical too.

Sungjae Im takes lead into Innisbrook finale

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Palm Harbour (US)

Sungjae Im was in position for a wire-to-wire victory in the Valspar Championship at Innisbrook after a slow start in his return from a wrist injury. Brandt Snedeker was right beside him in the final pairing – with a hot new putter in the bag. Im holed a sweeping 13-foot birdie putt on the par-4 18th hole Saturday for a 2-under 69 and a two-stroke lead over Snedeker, the 45-year-old US Presidents Cup captain playing on a sponsor exemption, and David Lipsky. Snedeker birdied three of the first four holes in a 67, and Lipsky had a 70 on the sunny afternoon with a high in the low-70s and wind gusting to 15 mph. After missing two straight cuts in his return, Im led by a stroke



after each of the first two rounds in firm and fast conditions on the Copperhead course, shooting 64-69. "I wasn't able to practise for two months," Im said. "So I think a lot of my shots that I didn't like from last year, I was able to, once I started practising, I was able to correct, and it's just been consistently getting better." On Saturday, Im played the front nine in 3 under,

with birdies on Nos. 1, 7 and 8. He bogeyed the par-4 12th and par-3 13th and got the left-to-right putt to fall on 18 to get to 11-under 202. "I was really happy that my play was good on the finishing stretch, 16 through 18," Im said. "And I'm really thrilled about the birdie on the final hole, and to have a two-shot lead going into tomorrow." The 27-year-old South Korean player has two

PGA Tour victories, the 2020 Honda Classic and 2021 Shriners Children's Open. "It's been a while since I've been in the lead like this," Im said. "I'm sure I will be nervous, but the best I can do is just to play my own game." Snedeker won the last of his nine PGA Tour titles in 2018 and had only two top 10s in the last year. He switched to a mallet putter a few weeks ago and has been on a tear on and around the greens this week. "I finished strong, made some good swings coming down the stretch," Snedeker said. "Rolling the ball so good, chipping the ball so good, if I can kind of get my long game under control a little bit, we're going to have a good chance tomorrow." Lipsky had five birdies and four bogeys. He's winless on the PGA Tour.

LeBron James breaks NBA games record

DICK SCANLON
■ Orlando

LeBron James set the NBA record by playing in his 1,612th regular-season game, and Luke Kennard made a 3-pointer with 0.6 seconds left to send the Los Angeles Lakers to a 105-104 comeback victory over the Orlando Magic. Luka Doncic scored 33 points in the Lakers' ninth straight win, but was called for his 16th technical foul – an automatic one-game suspension by the league if it's not rescinded. James had 12 points, six rebounds, four assists and



three steals on his record-breaking night, passing the mark Robert Parish held for

nearly 30 years. Paolo Banchemo, who led seven Magic players in double

figures with 16 points, blocked a shot by James out of bounds with 4.7 seconds left. After a replay review, it was determined that the ball had not caromed off James' foot out of bounds – and Los Angeles maintained possession. That set up Marcus Smart's pass to Kennard for the winning shot. Austin Reaves had 26 points for the Lakers. James scored six straight points midway through the third quarter to help Los Angeles take an eight-point lead, but Orlando led by five going into the final minute. It was the Magic's fourth straight loss. (AP)

AC Milan 3-2 victory over Torino in Serie A

DANIELLA MATARAP
■ Milan

AC Milan changed gears in the second half to storm to a 3-2 win over Torino and trim the gap to Serie A leader Inter Milan to six points. After a sluggish first period, Milan bagged two goals in as many minutes to secure the result over Torino. Milan moved back into second, a point above Napoli, which won at Cagliari 1-0 on Friday. Inter visits Fiorentina on Sunday. Torino had the better of the first half, although Milan managed to take the lead in the 37th minute with a stunning goal from defender Strahinja Pavlovic. A cross was cleared to about 25 meters out, where Pavlovic took a touch before



hitting a ridiculous strike on the half volley that looped up before coming down just between the bar and Alberto Paleari's outstretched hand. Giovanni Simeone levelled shortly before halftime, when some jeers rang out from the home fans. But whatever coach Massimiliano Allegri said to his players during the break

worked as Milan was a different side. Adrien Rabiot restored Milan's lead in the 54th, bundling in Christian Pulisic's cross with his knee, and Youssef Fofana extended the Rossoneri's advantage two minutes later. There was a nervy finale at San Siro as Nikola Vlasic pulled one back from the penalty spot after Pavlovic

was adjudged to have dragged down Simeone. Despite being hit by an outbreak of whooping cough, Sassuolo managed a 1-1 draw at Juventus. Sassuolo revealed on Friday that it informed the league's governing body that one of its squad members had a confirmed case of whooping cough and five additional team members were in isolation after showing symptoms consistent with the disease. The identities of those affected were not revealed. Kenan Yildiz gave Juventus the lead on Saturday, in the 14th minute, but Andrea Pinamonti leveled early in the second half. Juventus had a chance to snatch the win when it was awarded a penalty after a Dusan

Vlahovic header struck Sassuolo defender Jay Idzes on the arm. However, Manuel Locatelli's spot kick was weak and central and easily saved by visiting goalkeeper Arjanet Muric. Juventus remained fifth in a tight battle for fourth place and the final Champions League spot. There was some positive news for Juventus as Arkadiusz Milik made his long-awaited return from injury. The Poland forward has been out for nearly two years following a knee ligament injury in June 2024 and numerous setbacks in his recovery. Milik went on as a substitute in the 79th minute, along with Vlahovic, who was also returning from injury and making his first appearance since November. (AP)

Liverpool and Chelsea slump to defeats as Champions League hopes fade

STEVE DOUGLAS
■ Liverpool

A 10th Premier League loss of the campaign for Liverpool. A fourth straight defeat in 10 days for Chelsea. These are bruising times for two of the biggest-spending powerhouse clubs in English soccer. Forget about challenging for the Premier League title, at this rate they are struggling to even qualify for the Champions League. Liverpool's feeble title defense unraveled further on Saturday in a 2-1 loss at Brighton that extended the stuttering defending champion's winless run in the league to three matches. Danny

Welbeck scored both for Brighton at Amex Stadium, either side of Milos Kerkez's equaliser for Liverpool in its latest disjointed display under manager Arne Slot. A few hours later, Chelsea was dispatched by Everton 3-0, completing a miserable week in which the team was also bundled out of the Champions League by Paris Saint-Germain in a chastening 8-2 aggregate loss. Liverpool is hanging onto fifth spot in the league - a point and a place ahead of Chelsea. The Premier League is highly likely to again have five qualification spots for next season's Champions League, but even that might



not be enough for these two underperforming giants. Liverpool has taken just one point from its last three

league games and is a remarkable 21 points behind first-placed Arsenal with seven games left of the cam-

paign. The Reds became the first team since Chelsea in the 2017-18 season to lose 10 matches in a title defense. "It's not good enough, no matter how many excuses I come up with," said Slot, whose position is coming under scrutiny less than a year after leading Liverpool to a record-tying 20th English top-flight title. Among those excuses might be Liverpool's injury problems, which worsened when striker Hugo Ekitike hobbled off in the eighth minute with a dead leg. Slot did say after the match, however, that it wasn't serious. The Dutch coach was already without star winger

Mohamed Salah and goalkeeper Alisson Becker, who both got hurt this week, while Alexander Isak – signed for \$170 million last summer – has been out since December and hasn't been fully fit all season. Still, few could have expected Liverpool's title defence to be so underwhelming when the club spent a record \$570 million in last summer's transfer window to bolster a championship-winning squad. Watch out Liverpool and Chelsea, Everton is coming for your place in the top five. Beto scored twice and Iliman Ndiaye curled a shot into the top corner for the third as Everton outfought

Chelsea, which delivered a performance lacking in energy after its recent Champions League exertions. Chelsea manager Liam Rosenior said it was his team's most disappointing performance since he took charge in January. Everton was in eighth place – behind Brentford, which drew 0-0 at Leeds, on goal difference – and they were only three points behind Liverpool and two behind Chelsea. It also has a goalkeeper in red-hot form; Jordan Pickford produced another amazing save to tip over a close-range effort by Enzo Fernandez in the first half. Chelsea has won just one of its last six games in the

league, and that was at third-placed Aston Villa – another team limping to the finish line this season. Next-to-last Burnley slipped closer to relegation by squandering the lead and losing at Fulham 3-1. Josh King, Harry Wilson and Raul Jimenez – with a stoppage-time penalty – scored for Fulham after Zian Flemming put Burnley ahead in the 60th. Burnley was nine points from safety with seven games remaining and only three points above last-placed Wolverhampton. It was Jimenez's first goal since the death of his father last week, and the Mexico striker was reduced to tears after the match. (AP)



TALES AZZONI
■ Madrid

Elche left the relegation zone in La Liga by defeating Mallorca 2-1 for its first victory of the year, while Sevilla's struggles continued in a 2-0 home loss to Valencia. Elche scored twice in less than 10 minutes in the second half to earn the come-from-behind victory. Mallorca went ahead with a goal by Pablo Torre in the 58th minute, but Elche rallied with scores by Rafa Mir in the 62nd and Tete Morente in the 71st. The result moved Elche to 16th place, one point above the drop zone. It hadn't won a match across all competitions since December 21. It had lost eight of its last 12 games with four draws. Mallorca dropped to 18th place and entered the relegation zone. "Three months without a win, that's incredible," Elche coach Eder Sarabia said. "It was a tough winter for us here at Elche." Sevilla stayed three points above the bottom three after the loss to Valencia, which went up to 11th place with its

fourth victory in six matches. Hugo Duro and Largie Ramazani scored first-half goals for the visitors. Sevilla has only one win in its last seven games. "We can't play like this," Sevilla midfielder Djibril Sow said. "Now we have a series of finals ahead, and we have to improve. Our goal is to fight against relegation." Valencia defender Jose Luis Gaya and Sevilla forward Juanlu had to be taken to a hospital for exams for head injuries after twice colliding with each other in the first half, according to Spanish media. The players continued playing after the collisions but eventually were substituted. Espanyol extended its winless streak in 2026 to 12 games after a 2-1 home loss to Getafe. Getafe moved to eighth place, two spots ahead of Espanyol. Osasuna defeated Girona 1-0 with an 80th-minute goal by Ante Budimir, halting a three-game winless run. In a match between bottom-table teams, 19th-placed Levante beat 20th-placed Oviedo 4-2 at home. (AP)

Spinners shine as South Africa beats New Zealand by 19 runs

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Wellington

New Zealand foundered against South Africa's spinners as the Proteas won the fourth Twenty20 by 19 runs Sunday to level the five-match series at 2-2. Connor Esterhuizen made a maiden half-century from 33 balls as South Africa scored 164-5 after choosing to bat. Esterhuizen eventually was out for 57, and his innings made the difference between the teams.

New Zealand was ahead at 63-2 after the powerplay with Tim Robinson making 32 from 22 balls at the top of the order. But left-armers Prenelan Subrayen took 2-13 on debut, and Keshav Maharaj took 2-22 to cut through the New Zealand middle order and turn the match in South Africa's favour.

Dane Cleaver made 26 from 16 balls, returning to the New Zealand lineup after almost three years. He looked dangerous when he was beaten and bowled by a Subrayen delivery. Bevon Jacobs was also bowled by Subrayen when the ball dipped under his bat.

Jimmy Neesham (10) was dropped twice, then caught in the same over from Ottnell Baartman, who took 2-30 from four overs. Maharaj removed Nick Kelly (16) and Cole McConchie (10) as the spinners pinned down the New Zealand batters by varying their pace and flight.

"I thought a total of 164 was about par, maybe a bit below



par," New Zealand captain Jimmy Neesham said. "We certainly had a chance going into the second half of the game.

"A few average options and poor execution, and we came out on the wrong side of it."

New Zealand's already depleted lineup was further reduced by the loss of Tom Latham to injury and Devon Conway, Mitchell Santner and Lockie Ferguson for the last two matches of the series.

Esterhuizen rallied South Africa after it had lost Wiaan Mulder to the second ball of its innings, a maiden bowled by Kyle Jamieson.

The right-hander hit a six and a four from the third over, a six and four in the fourth over, a six and two fours

among 17 runs in the fifth over, keeping the South Africa run-rate up. South Africa was 50-1 after the powerplay, its best start of the series so far.

Esterhuizen reached his half-century in the 10th over with a boundary from Ben Sears, the sixth four of his innings that also included three sixes.

"I just tried to keep it as simple as possible to be honest," Esterhuizen said. "I didn't have much time to think about it because I was out there straight away.

"So I just tried to stick to a game plan, and it came off tonight." Esterhuizen looked set to go big when he was brilliantly caught by Katene Clarke on debut, running in and diving forward from deep

square leg. Tony de Zorzi, who was the quiet partner in an 81-run stand with Esterhuizen for the second wicket, was out next over for 23 from 21 balls.

Rubin Hermann and Dian Forrester put on 38 for the fourth wicket, keeping the South Africa total ticking over. Forrester made 19 from 14 balls before being trapped lbw by a yorker from Zak Foulkes.

Hermann made an unbeaten 28 from 25 balls, Jason Smith scored 19 from 15, and George Linde added 14 from eight, but New Zealand reined in South Africa's scoring a little at the death. Only 43 runs came from the last five overs, and Sears allowed only one run from the bat in the final over.



India tour to test Australia as CA unveils gruelling 2026-27 schedule

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Melbourne

Cricket Australia on Sunday unveiled its 2026-27 international calendar with a packed itinerary leaving little turn-around time ahead of the marquee Border-Gavaskar Trophy in India, expected to begin in mid or late-January.

The five-Test away series against India next year is set to be a decisive phase in an unprecedented and taxing schedule for Pat Cummins' ageing side.

Australia are slated to play 10 Tests in a 14-week window between December and March, making it one of the most demanding stretches in their history.

The home season will commence in August 2026, with two Tests against Bangladesh and conclude in March 2027 with a day-night spectacle at the MCG — the 150th anniversary Test against England.

The home series against New Zealand has been squeezed into a window of just over four weeks, while Australia's tour of South Africa later this year runs until the end of October, followed by an eight-match white-ball series against England in November.

"That Border-Gavaskar Trophy tour, a final frontier for the likes of Cummins, Steve Smith, Mitchell Starc, Josh Hazlewood and Nathan Lyon, who have never won a series in India, will also be a quick-fire campaign given CA's anniversary Test begins back in Melbourne on March 11," CA said in a statement.

"The call to hold back all three of Starc, Cummins and Hazlewood from at least the first few rounds of the soon-to-begin IPL shows CA is wary of getting their trio to the finishing line of the intense 2026-27 run," it added.

In potentially make-or-break season, LSG skipper Pant to bat at three

BHARAT SHARMA ■ New Delhi

Lucknow Super Giants (LSG) captain Rishabh Pant is set to bat at number three in a potentially make-or-break IPL season beginning on March 28.

Stakes are high for Pant going into the second season as LSG skipper with the franchise having shelled out a record ₹27 crore for his services at the 2025 mega auction.

Following the disappointment of last year, a successful season as a leader as well as a top-order batter can make him part of India's T20 plans going forward.

Across formats, Pant is only an integral member of the Indian Test side while

being a backup wicket-keeper to KL Rahul in ODIs.

The 28-year-old lost his place in the T20 side following India's World Cup triumph in 2024 and would need to do something special to make a comeback, considering Sanju Samson and Ishan Kishan have made themselves automatic picks by the sheer weight of their recent performances.

Therefore, the upcoming IPL is not just about delivering on an exorbitant price tag; it is also about staying relevant in the shortest format.

Pant majorly batted at number four last season before rightly pushing himself to number three towards the end of the



season, by when it was too late to turn LSG's fortunes.

Nicholas Pooran will move down the order to make way for Pant, with number

four, five, and six being used as floating positions.

The squad had a camp in Chennai, and at the moment, they are going through the

The LSG middle-order comprises Pooran, Ayush Badoni, Abdul Samad and Shabaz Ahmed.

Bowling was LSG's weakest link last season, with pacers including Mayank Yadav and Mohsin Khan not available due to injuries. The other pace options include Avesh Khan and Anrich Nortje, who is another injury-prone quick.

"The batting is settled. The bowling group looks a lot better than last year, but the combinations are yet to be worked out. Mayank is fit but needs to bowl a lot more in the nets. Hopefully, he will repay the faith the team has shown him over the past four to five years," the source added. (PTI)

Dasun Shanaka set to join Rajasthan Royals as Sam Curran's replacement

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

In yet another blow to the Pakistan Super League, Sri Lanka captain and all-rounder Dasun Shanaka is set to join the Rajasthan Royals as a replacement for the injured Sam Curran in the upcoming Indian Premier League.

The move will make Shanaka the latest player to switch from the PSL to the IPL after Zimbabwe pacer Blessing Muzarabani pulled out of his contract with Islamabad United to join Kolkata Knight Riders as a replacement for



Mustafizur Rahman.

"Dasun's signing is pending owing to his paperwork in the PSL, which is a

paign against Chennai Super Kings in Guwahati, their home venue, in the first phase of the IPL schedule that has been announced so far.

Under Shanaka's leadership, co-hosts Sri Lanka had crashed out in the Super Eight stage of the T20 World Cup.

Shanaka scored 165 runs, including a 31-ball 76 not out against Pakistan, while he also took three wickets in the T20 World Cup.

Having gone unsold at the IPL's mini-auction last December, Shanaka was picked up by PSL franchise Lahore Qalandars.



PSL will be held from March 26, no spectators allowed: PCB chairman

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Lahore

The Pakistan Cricket Board (PCB) on Sunday announced that the initial stages of the Pakistan Super League (PSL) will be held without spectators due to the prevailing tense situation in the region caused by the Iran-USA-Israel conflict.

PCB chairman, Mohsin Naqvi, said it had also been decided that the latest PSL edition will be restricted to two venues — Karachi and Lahore.

"The PSL is an international brand and our pride. So, the league will be held on schedule from 26th March, but no spectators will be allowed," Naqvi told a media conference.

However, Naqvi, flanked by PSL CEO Salman Naseer, downplayed any security concerns about holding the PSL in Pakistan.

"These decisions were

taken because of the austerity measures announced by the Government due to the situation in the region. I can tell you overseas players will start reaching Pakistan from tonight," Naqvi said.

He also said that, as part of the austerity measures, the board had cancelled the grand opening ceremony ahead of the PSL.

Naqvi said the board would try to compensate the eight franchises by paying them the estimated gate money at the already announced venues — Faisalabad, Rawalpindi, Peshawar and Multan.

Naqvi also said the PCB legal department will pursue the cases of cricketers who cancelled their PSL contracts to join the Indian Premier League.

"But you can see how top List A players are joining the PSL, and that shows the growth of our league," he added.

Punjab Kings are moving in right direction: Irfan Pathan

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Former India all-rounder Irfan Pathan says Punjab Kings are finally "moving in the right direction" after making smart and bold choices at the auction table, raising hopes of ending their long wait for an Indian Premier League title.

Speaking on 'IPL Today Live', Pathan credited Punjab's improved clarity in leadership and squad-building for their turnaround. Punjab finished as runner-up last season, losing the close final to Royal Challengers Bengaluru.

"Leadership has played a huge role in Punjab's turnaround. You win half the IPL



at the auction table. Big purses don't necessarily mean you will always get what you want, but they did, and they reached the final," he said.

Pathan pointed out that the franchise has not shied away from taking tough calls, including releasing underperforming players such as Glenn Maxwell, while also strengthening their bench.

"They took bold but important calls... and now you see all-rounders like Azmatullah Omarzai, Marco Jansen and Marcus Stoinis, along with a young Indian batting core. They also went all-out for Shreyas Iyer after deciding he would be the captain. There is clarity of thought, and I feel Punjab have started to move



in the right direction," he said.

Starting from scratch is not easy

Pathan also reflected on Delhi Capitals' past struggles, particularly in identifying and

nurturing talent.

"When you let go of players like AB de Villiers, and you had Andre Russell, starting from scratch is not easy. There were discussions about giving Russell

more opportunities, but they just couldn't find a place for him consistently. Identification of talent is very important, and I feel Delhi used to fall short in that area," he said.

Sports have now become priority in Bihar: Olympic gold medallist Abhinav Bindra

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Patna

Olympic gold medallist Abhinav Bindra on Sunday said sports have now become a priority in Bihar and hailed the State Government for developing infrastructure in the sector.

Talking to reporters on the sidelines of the Bihar Sports Conclave organised collaboratively by the State Government and Sportstar,

he said, "The way sports are being developed in Bihar is truly admirable. Bihar's sports minister was my colleague in shooting. She is deeply committed to the growth of sports." Bindra, the first Indian to win an individual gold medal at the Olympics in Beijing 2008, also appreciated the efforts of officials in promoting sports and organising such conclaves, which, he said, "provide space for deliberation".

Bengal boys favourites as 87th National TT Championships begin

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Gandhidham (Gujarat)

A total of 32 teams will battle for top honours when the boys U-15 team competition of the 87th Inter-State Sub-Junior and Cadet National Table Tennis Championships begins in Gandhidham on Monday.

West Bengal players arrive as clear favourites, topping the cumulative standings with 600 points and carrying the weight of expectations in the absence of a weakened



PSPB Academy, the defending champions.

The Bengal squad features

a strong core group in Aditya Das, Rishaab Chattopadhyay, Himson Kumar Mondal, and

watched sides, however, will be the hosts Gujarat, who are placed fourth with 182 points but bring significant promise through their line-up of Vivaan Dave, Dev Bhatt, Dwij Bhalodia, and Aarva Singhvi.

Despite its legacy, the Academy team finds itself down the order in seventh spot, with a relatively new roster comprising Sathish Karmeghakannan, Viren Patil, and Dhrityaman Pandey, and may find it tough to match the depth of the top-ranked sides this time.